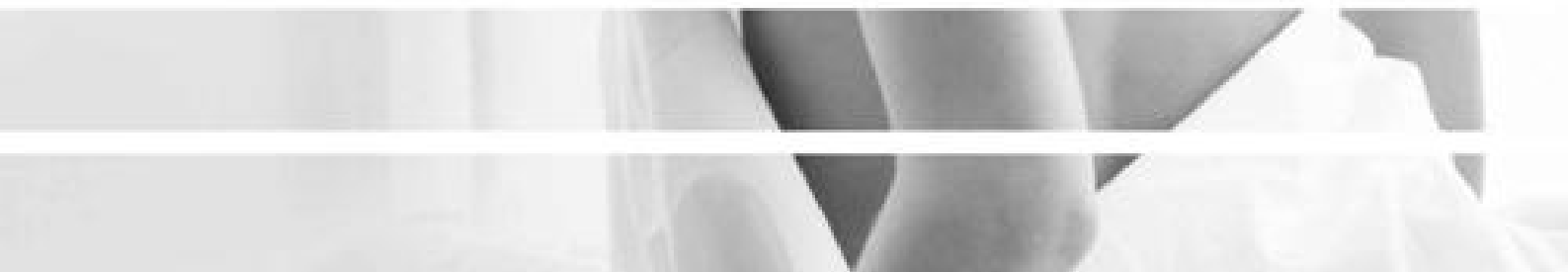




Madeleine Wakes

A WIFE-WATCHING ROMANCE



MAX SEBASTIAN



BOOK ONE OF THE MADELEINE TRILOGY

Madeleine Wakes

Copyright © 2014 by Max Sebastian
All rights reserved.

Edited by Kenny Wright

Cover Design by Kenny Wright

Cover image © Arman Zhenikeyev | Dreamstime.com

First digital edition electronically published by KW Publishing, February 2014

First print edition published by KW Publishing, January 2014

Printed by CreateSpace, Charleston SC

This is a work of fiction, any similarity to actual persons, living or dead, or events, organizations or locations, is purely coincidental.

Reproduction in whole or in part of this publication without written consent is strictly prohibited, other than limited quotes for purposes of review.

The author greatly appreciates you taking the time to read this book, please do consider leaving a review wherever you bought this title, to help others find this story.

Contents

[Cover](#)

[Copyright Information](#)

[*Madeleine Wakes*](#)

[Foreword](#)

[Chapter One](#)

[Chapter Two](#)

[Chapter Three](#)

[Chapter Four](#)

[Chapter Five](#)

[Chapter Six](#)

[Chapter Seven](#)

[Chapter Eight](#)

[Chapter Nine](#)

[Chapter Ten](#)

[Chapter Eleven](#)

[Chapter Twelve](#)

[Chapter Thirteen](#)

[Chapter One of *Madeleine Plays*](#)

[Acknowledgements](#)

[About the author](#)

[Other books by Max Sebastian](#)

Madeleine Wakes

BOOK ONE OF THE MADELEINE TRILOGY

M A X S E B A S T I A N

“I had to touch you with my hands, I had to taste you with my tongue;
one can’t love and do nothing.”

- Graham Greene, The End of the Affair

Foreword by Kenny Wright

If you like wife-watching romances, then you are in for a treat. The book that you hold in your hands—or on your screen, or e-reader, or whatever—is the most thorough telling of the fantasy that I’ve ever read. If there are such things as epics in this genre, then Madeleine Wakes surely classifies.

I’ve been involved with this project for many months, watching it grow, watching it evolve, watching as Hugo himself watches his wife undergo her powerful transformation. Max wanted to tell the story of one man’s desire to watch his wife with other men from the very beginning. Madeleine and Hugo come into this story as clean slates, and walk out of it awoken to the sexy—sometimes uncomfortable—but always loving—adventures of wife-sharing.

I’m lucky to count Max not only as an author I can trust, but as a friend. He’s a guy who really gets this subgenre. He understands that even though these stories introduce sex outside of marriage, it’s the relationship between husband and wife that is central to the story. That relationship is the central character, and it’s that relationship that we see challenged, conflicted, evolving, and finally resolving.

And if you like this story and are looking for more in its vein (shameless plug incoming), Max and I have teamed up with authors Kirsten McCurran and Ben Boswell to create a new site: eroticaformen.com. You won’t simply find wife-watching books there. You will find character-driven, plotted books—many of which are written from a male perspective, but not all—where relationships are central and HEAs are plentiful. Despite the name, the books aren’t for men alone, but they appeal to me, and since I’m a guy, I can only speak for myself.

But first things first, sit back, grab your beverage of choice, and enjoy Madeleine Wakes. I'm envious that you get to experience it for the first time.

Kenny Wright

kennywriter.com

One

Hugo awoke in the middle of the night to the sound of Madeleine crying, and as ever it made his blood run cold. She wasn't lying in the bed next to him—it sounded as though she'd gone out into the living room. He waited a moment, cautious, pausing to determine that he wasn't mistaken.

The quiet, plaintive noise continued.

He had no doubt what she was doing. Trying to hide her sadness from him, just when he'd been so hopeful she was in full recovery. It made him feel as though his insides were being eaten away by acid.

Ever since they'd moved to a new city, starting afresh, Madeleine had seemed to be getting better, happier, leaving the past behind. It was a bitter disappointment to find this wasn't the case. After everything she'd been through, and all the effort she'd put in to haul herself out of the condition that had plagued her for so long, now it looked as though she'd been putting on a happy face all along.

He loved her for her selflessness, but keeping the bad feelings to herself wasn't a healthy way to deal with it.

Her crying wasn't particularly loud—he was surprised she'd woken him at all. During their last year or so in Boston, his senses had become so dulled to his wife's tears that it had no longer woken him. Now it seemed he was back to the old pattern, from the early days, of waking up at the slightest sign of distress.

How blissfully happy she'd been in recent days, after getting her new job. Had none of that been real?

"It's nothing really," she'd said modestly when she'd revealed the news. But he'd seen in her face how important it was to her, and the

simple fact that she'd come to meet him after work to go for a celebratory meal showed how significant it was to her.

"It's fantastic, honey. I'm so pleased."

"It's just working in a bookstore. I mean, it's not even writing anything."

"It's perfect—you always loved hanging out in bookstores. And when you're ready, maybe it'll be a platform to build on."

"It will, won't it?"

Then her face was breaking out into that pretty smile, the brightness in her whole demeanor making Hugo feel slightly weak at the knees, offering him a glimpse of the Madeleine he had married before things had turned so bleak.

They'd gone out to celebrate—mimosas at Benji's. And she'd been so cheerful, so up-beat—had all that been put on for his benefit? Was she secretly gloomy that her new position didn't have the same kind of status as her old reporting job at the Globe?

In the darkness, Hugo now hauled himself up from the mattress, trying to keep positive. Maybe some isolated incident had upset her. Something tangible, something he could contend with in cheering her up. They could sort this out, they could cope with whatever it was that had caused this setback. They had to.

He padded silently over the carpet to the bedroom door, his heart aching at the soft sound of sorrow from his wife, wondering whether this was the first time she'd snuck out of the bedroom to vent her pent-up feelings like this—or whether this had happened many times before.

Hugo paused in the small hallway that led from the bedroom through to the cramped but open-plan kitchen-living area. Hearing her like this always brought back the sharp bite of guilt. It had dogged him all through his wife's illness, from the very beginning. On the surface, he knew he'd done everything he could to help her, but deep down, he'd never been able to shift the feeling that he was a husband who couldn't

manage the most basic thing in a marriage—to make his beloved wife happy.

From the hallway, he could hear her heavy breathing—irregular, ponderous and constantly interrupted by sobs and sighs or the occasional quiet moan. She was so clearly trying to contain her noise, to keep from waking her husband. She knew he had to get up early to go to work in the morning, he needed his sleep. She didn't want to weigh him down with worries about her condition.

A series of staccato breaths made him certain she was really sobbing. This was truly another step back in their long, arduous journey together.

He stood still for a moment, frozen to the spot as though needing to build up his strength before he laid eyes on her. Before he saw her back in the tight grip of profound misery. A quiet sigh escaped his lips as he racked his tired mind for something to say that might calm her down, distract her even momentarily from the darkness.

We'll find a new therapist, he might suggest. I mean, from what you were saying, this Dr. Simeon has some fairly strange ideas, right?

Or perhaps something more positive for her to focus on: *Why don't we plan a vacation somewhere?"*

Or more drastic: *D'you think maybe New York's just not the best place for us just now?*

He always felt so useless when his wife was upset. He could embrace her, hold her tight, but he never felt he was doing much good. She always told him it helped, but really, he was sure it did nothing for her, nothing to tackle the cause of the pain that had seized hold ever since that awful day three years ago when their pregnancy had turned sour.

He felt so exhausted standing there listening to her. There was no inspiration coming to him, he was out of ideas.

I'm sorry, honey, it's just the way it is.

He slowly drew in a lungful of oxygen, gearing himself up for the effort it was going to take to calm her, to apologize for everything, to assure her it would get better, they'd find a way. But then, just before making a move, something held him back.

He couldn't pin down what it was at first. Was there a slightly different tone, a different cadence to her crying compared to what he remembered from those years of depression? Some kind of subtle disparity from her usual bout of melancholy. Perhaps fatigue was playing tricks on his mind.

More heavy breathing, and another few soft sighs.

Hugo felt his ears prick up, along with something else down below as he started to consider an alternative hypothesis concerning her cries. Madeleine emitted another little sigh, and it sounded somehow...beautiful. Melodic. Delicate, sweet—but not necessarily miserable.

He waited, listening.

And it slowly dawned on him exactly what Madeleine was doing all alone sitting on the window seat out in the living room.

Jesus.

It was perfectly natural, of course, that she might want to relieve some pent-up desire. But Madeleine had been so desexualized ever since the condition had taken hold, it was a shock to Hugo to hear her now expressing herself in this way.

Considering the fact that the condition and its debasing affects had robbed their relationship of any real intimacy, it couldn't be a surprise to Hugo that Madeleine should now be taking care of herself like this. But it still seemed somehow startling to him.

He'd never really challenged the loss of their sexual connection—he'd always felt it might come across to Madeleine as though he was complaining that she wasn't servicing him properly as a wife should, when it was quite clear she just wasn't ever in the mood under the brutal

yoke of her depression. He hadn't really thought about it much since they'd come to New York, even as she had started to move back toward some kind of normality. He'd always figured that when she was ready, she would make it clear enough she wanted to rekindle things. Perhaps that time was drawing near. It was an exciting prospect.

Hugo felt his manhood thicken dramatically as he continued to listen to her.

He felt strong temptation to just go straight out there and pounce on her, hoping she was game for their first real liaison in years. Yet for some reason he kept back, fearing how she might react. She might be frightened by his sudden appearance, she might reject his overtures. She might not be ready.

She might even feel he was invading her privacy, in knowing what she was doing, and any resulting anger could kill any hopes of a rekindling.

However, understanding he was of her need to take things at her own speed, Hugo found his respect for her personal space totally overwhelmed by his formidable curiosity. He might be able to hold himself back from jumping her bones, but he couldn't tear himself away from those sweet sounds she was making. He wanted to see.

His heart was pounding as he detected the slight hint of spice in the air from her arousal. Her soft sighs, quiet moans, the sudden gasps for breath, the constant deep rhythm as her chest rose and fell, it was like music to his ears, truly bewitching.

She was giving pleasure to herself, and in doing so it gave pleasure to him.

He edged toward the corner, one eye creeping out to see the kitchen area, and over toward the windows where Madeleine was sitting.

The blinds were drawn, but in the darkness enough amber light filtered through the slats from the street to reveal her stunning beauty as she sat there, up against the far wall, her long dirty blonde hair flowing

loose down her back, one leg lodged against the window, the other hanging off the edge to expose her little white panties. Her nipples were rock hard under the thin pink t-shirt she'd worn to bed, jostling against the material as she stirred. There was no sign of the sweatpants she'd also worn to bed.

Hugo had to stifle a groan as he watched her fingers move under the thin cotton of her underwear, her body undulating to the rhythm of her caresses.

God, she was so sexy.

There had been a time when they'd first been dating, that she'd let him watch her touching herself. It had never been long stretches, never through to orgasm, but it had been a serious turn-on at the time. Seeing her pleasing herself, her body responding with such grace to her expert ministrations. Was it inevitable that that kind of naughty little playfulness had disappeared from their relationship? Even before their long sexual hiatus, marriage had turned their love-making into a shorthand abbreviation of what it once was.

Madeleine now raised her hips to slip off her panties, revealing the soft patch of fair hair nestled between her thighs, a sight that made Hugo let out a quiet gasp. She turned her head sharply, angling her ears toward him, freezing as she strained to detect any threat, or any suggestion that her husband had awoken.

Hugo slipped back behind the corner, heart thumping, fearful of discovery.

He could only wait, heart beat after heart beat, focused on breathing as quietly as humanly possible. His silence stretched out, long enough to reassure his beautiful wife that her privacy was still safe, that her innocent husband remained shut away in their bedroom.

He risked another glimpse, slipping one eye back out into the open. In the street outside, a particularly loud vehicle driving by seemed to offer some kind of explanation for anything that had disturbed her,

making her visibly relax so she could finish dragging her panties down over her knees and off past her feet.

Hugo took more care to control himself as she now dropped her underwear on the floor beside her, and in the dim orange-hued light he could see her thighs open up to reveal that exquisite little flower, her fingers splaying out through her soft down toward her dewy lips.

Oh, she was such an exquisite creature. Was it morally wrong to watch her like this?

Hugo wanted so badly to just go over there and join her now, to touch her as she was touching herself, feel the softness of her skin, the heat of her body, the wetness of her sex. But if he did, he felt sure she would be embarrassed, awkward, and even guilty that she'd been touching herself in secret rather than initiating anything with him.

He also suspected that if he suddenly appeared and she did accept him, her attention would turn to pleasing him, ensuring he had a suitable orgasm, sacrificing her own pleasure in so doing. Hugo wanted her to come, he really needed to see her fulfill her own conclusion, as though to verify it was still possible. The only real guarantee he had was to leave her be—she was the best qualified for that particular task.

So he merely stood back and quietly teased himself with his craving for her.

What was she thinking about while her hands glided over those wonderful curves, her fingers slipping over her mound and into her soaking pussy? Women were such a mystery, even when you married them. Was she imagining him in some way? Some passionate experience from the past?

It was glorious to see her giving herself such pleasure, such a searing sight to see her moving with such poise and finesse, her fingers sinking inside her slippery folds, teasing out those wonderful little moans, those sexy little gasps.

The longer she went on, the more she seemed reassured by the continuing stillness of the night, that her actions were not encroaching on her husband's sleep. Yet he could still hear that cute little nervous tremor in her breathing as her fingers danced over her curves and between her thighs.

Her body slumped down on the window seat so that she was almost horizontal, her eyes closed, focused on only the sensations from her touch. She began to suck her breath through her teeth as her fingers stirred her sex in continuous circles, and she now seemed resolved to go all the way.

Hugo marveled at her flowing, elegant motion, her body writhing and rocking almost as though liquid, those curves so eloquent in expressing the sensations she felt as she moved, her hands building up the pace toward her imminent climax.

God, she was the sexiest creature he'd ever known.

She had such an enigmatic glint in her eye, he wished he had a window into what she was thinking. Were women like guys, picturing some hot model or celebrity when they touched themselves? Fantasizing about some movie they'd once seen. He'd never really raised it with Madeleine, the subject of masturbation seeming inappropriate even between a married couple.

What do you think about when you stroke yourself, Madeleine? Are you imagining me? My hard cock sinking into your tightness, filling you up, stirring inside you? Or are you dreaming of some unattainable fantasy hunk?

He'd never really thought about the prospect of Madeleine fantasizing about models or actors, but it was only natural if she did. As a younger man, he supposed it would have made him feel jealous, though the reality was he himself lusted after models and actresses from time to time. Tonight, he found he didn't mind if she was dreaming of some

poster boy or other. He was ecstatic she was getting back in touch with her sexuality at all.

Are you picturing his bulging pecs, that washboard stomach grazing over you as his unattainable fantasy cock thrusts into you? Naughty girl...

Her breath started to take on an urgent stutter, as though she were shivering from the cold, interspersed with the kind of gasps for oxygen that made it almost sound as though she were somehow suffering. She was close to her peak.

Her darkly exhilarating scent was now strong enough in the air that he could sense it without doubt. What an incredible experience it was to witness her in such free abandon—he felt euphoric from it all.

“Oh yeah...” she let out a forced whisper, as though unable to contain the words. “Oh God yeah... oh yeah...”

Hugo wasn’t sure when he’d started touching his hardness while watching her, but now he was aware that if he wasn’t careful, he’d make a mess. It was difficult to control himself, though, as he heard her vocalize the powerful sensations blooming inside her.

“Oh... oh fuck yeah... Oh God...”

The sight of her silent scream as she came—the open mouth, the flushed cheeks, the eyes squeezed tightly closed, those two little vertical lines showing between her eyebrows, her head tilting back as the feelings shuddered through her entire body—that was the biggest turn-on for Hugo. Nothing staged for his benefit: just real, honest, overwhelming satisfaction.

What more could a husband want for his wife?

TWO

Hugo's own new job had started as soon as they'd moved to New York, of course, since it was what had enticed them down from New England in the first place.

In those first few months, Madeleine had done all the unpacking, shaping up the apartment in their own image, taking on the lion's share of the process of setting up home, to allow Hugo space to focus on his work.

She'd been doing a cursory search of the newspapers and websites for suitable jobs as well, but Hugo didn't want to put any pressure on her in that direction. Putting any kind of weight on her shoulders was never going to help her shrug off the burden of her condition. She'd pursue work when she was ready.

While he'd been prizing himself out of bed at ungodly hours in the morning, returning late at night, he got the impression she spent a lot of her days sitting in the window, as she had back in Boston, reading her Kindle or gazing out at life across the street.

And there was a lot of that. The apartment buildings on this street not far from Washington Square were disturbingly close together, the windows so close it almost felt as though you could reach out and touch them. There had been a reason he'd chosen this place above all the others. Madeleine's lack of interest in where they lived was a lingering part of her depression, but he'd been able to explain the other virtues of this apartment to her sufficiently enough, he thought, to even persuade the old Madeleine.

If she ended up permanently entrenched on that window seat, her melancholy taking hold once again, at least she'd be able to people-

watch. To see others going about their daily lives—it might help her re-engage with life herself, he figured.

He saw her at weekends sitting there, watching, and knew his instincts had to be at least half-right. She liked looking into those apartments, with their wall-to-wall windows, high ceilings and gorgeous interiors. The occupants had to be wealthy, their designer furniture and spacious floor plans a cut above anything in Hugo and Madeleine's building, Number 147.

Their more affluent neighbors also rarely seemed to shut out the world with blinds or curtains—and Hugo didn't think for a moment it was because they wanted to show off the trappings of their success. It was as though a life of living within view of others had vaccinated them against the need for personal privacy.

"They've got nothing to hide," Madeleine told him one day when he commented on it.

"I guess not. Nice apartments to show off to the neighbors."

She shrugged, "They're proud of what they've achieved."

He'd nodded at that, painfully aware that their own apartment was a quarter the size of those across the street. "D'you ever wish we were like that?" he'd asked her. "Maybe if you hadn't married another reporter..."

He hadn't realized until the words came out of his mouth that it was a downer of a question, not something he would have normally directed her way. It must have been the change of scene, bringing his safeguards down.

But Madeleine had merely smiled, batting away the sentiment. "Marry someone other than you?" she'd said, and her tone was that of amusement, taking Hugo a little by surprise. It seemed that they hadn't shared a moment of amusement in forever. It gave him a little sugary warm feeling inside.

"Well, you must have had countless offers before me," he'd said, returning her smile. "All those movie stars and rock stars and hipsters

you used to hang with.”

“I used to interview. Not the same as hang with,” she’d said. “Their offers were only ever a quick jump in the sack.”

The vague picture of a younger Madeleine being presented with the option of a bed with some of the big names she’d written about in her heyday caused a flicker of jealousy deep within his gut, but he knew her well enough. She’d been ruthlessly ambitious back then, and a virtual librarian when it came to her social life.

“Besides, you gave me that beautiful little sparkly ring,” she’d laughed, holding up her hand to flash the dual bands of gold—engagement and wedding rings—as though it were proof she’d made the right decision all along.

The sound of her laughter, such unbridled and genuine joy, made him feel like he’d just won the lottery. She’d always had that affect on him—he just hadn’t really felt it in a while. This resurgent Madeleine gave him such hope. She seemed more motivated than ever to get back to some form of normality.

Was it the change of scene, the fresh start?

Was it the hours she spent watching those affluent Manhattanites in the mansion-like apartments across the street?

Was it her new therapist, her new treatment regime?

The fact that she’d even signed up for formal therapy in the first place had to be a good sign—it was something she’d studiously avoided back in Boston, even going so far as to scour dozens of papers on why therapy could do little to really help combat depression other than by prescribing drugs, which Madeleine had never been comfortable taking.

So her transformation had begun before starting therapy, although the unusual Dr. Simeon may have helped accelerate it.

And now, here she was with a job.

He liked the idea of his wife mingling with books and the bookish, spending her days among the quiet shelves, helping customers thanks to

her impressive literary knowledge. A bookstore had to be a rare thing these days, after the same digital revolution that had so hampered Madeleine's promising career and set Hugo on the track to the dark side—public relations. It was like she was hitting back.

And what place could be more sheltered and protective for someone hauling themselves out of the remaining traces of mental anguish than a book store?

Hugo came home to an empty apartment, and it felt strangely exhilarating to know that Madeleine wasn't there, she was out and about, getting things done, interacting with people, returning to the ins and outs of life in the city.

Some days she was home for dinner after the end of her shift, some days she was kept out longer by the store's extended opening hours. It all seemed healthy to Hugo, who'd come to dread returning home to their little pad in Charlestown every evening to find a despondent wife waiting for him, so dependent, so isolated from the world around them.

The night she'd phoned while he'd been walking to the subway, to say she was thinking of going to a bar with some of her co-workers—that had felt like Christmas to Hugo.

"Of course it's all right, sweetheart, you don't need to ask me," he'd said, some of the other commuters around him giving him quizzical and disapproving glances—New Yorkers reacting to the visible signs of joy on his face.

"I don't know if I really know them all that well yet—"

Her voice revealed a slight faltering hesitation, a dip in her new confidence, and he recognized that peculiar ability of her condition to persuade her that consorting with other people, doing anything other than hiding, was likely to be fraught with pain and complication.

"Which is why it'll be a great chance for you to bond, right? I'm sure you'll have a great time."

"They didn't say anything about inviting partners..."

“You don’t need me there,” he chuckled. “It’ll be a lot more fun without your boring husband along for the ride.”

“I get so tired in the evenings now that I’m working.”

“I tell you what,” he said. “I’ll call you in a couple hours, see how you’re doing. If you’re not having a great time, we can pretend I’m asking you to come home to deal with something urgent.”

“Okay.” Her quiet voice made him wonder if he was pushing her too much in this, though he felt she needed it.

Later on, he’d phoned her feeling nervous that she’d be all miserable and regret going out to the bar, the whole thing threatening her relationship with her co-workers and all the progress she’d made in her new job. But there on the crackly line over a loud cacophony of background voices, her sweet soprano voice had been so very bright and cheerful.

“Hey sweetie!”

“Hey honey, having a good time?”

“Fantastic!” So bouncy, so effervescent. “You mind if I stay out later?”

“Of course, sounds good to me!”

She’d even given him the feeling she wanted him off the phone quick, so she could get back to some conversation or other with the book crowd. It left Hugo with a quiet grin plastered across his face. She really was becoming the girl he’d married again.

Home alone for the night, he had the rare privilege of reacquainting himself with the art of relaxation. In this case, an evening of CSI and a ridiculously over-filled Calzone from the deli around the corner.

When she’d eventually come home after her first real night out in ages, more than a little affected by alcohol, she’d been the picture of happiness. The sight of her like that, so vivacious and giggly—even bordering on loopy as he’d helped her avoid falling over on the way into the bedroom—made him react quite physically to her beauty.

He hadn't had such a powerful erection in years.

It probably helped that she was wearing the shortest skirt he'd ever seen her wear, something he never even knew she owned. Did she really wear things like that to work?

"I want to stay up a little..." she'd said, protesting against his encouragement for her to lie down on the bed, though as soon as she touched the mattress, she was collapsing back, eyes closing, muscles falling limp as sleep consumed her.

He had undressed her, to get her into her PJs, as he had done many times before during her blackest periods in Charlestown. Only this time, he found himself caught up in the cloud of her sweet perfume, thinking how god-damned good she looked right now. Had she put extra highlights in her hair? She was certainly wearing more make-up than usual—but now he removed her shirt, the extravagance of her lace bra also struck him as unfamiliar.

Along with the shortness of her skirt, it all suggested to him real self-confidence in her. This was a great sign.

Peeling off her skirt and her black nylons, seeing her that way before he dutifully began slipping her into her nightwear, it also inspired such fervent lust in him that Hugo knew he'd have to take care of business before coming to bed himself.

Madeleine was becoming—or had already become, at any rate—drop-dead gorgeous again and it reminded Hugo just how long it had been since they'd shared any kind of passion together.

Maybe there would be opportunity to initiate something some time soon, a seduction. Was that appropriate at this stage in their relationship? They were married, there shouldn't be any need for seduction. Married people just looked at each other, recognizing the need for sex in each other's eyes, and then they just hopped into bed, didn't they?

It felt to Hugo as though he had to woo Madeleine all over again—but he'd never been any good at that, it had been hard enough the first

time.

*

He came home Friday nights, sometimes other nights during the week, and she was still out with her friends from the book store, and he felt great.

He knew that on a selfish level, it felt good having a little personal space for a while, after so many months and years in which every minute outside work had been filled with taking care of her. It was a breather for him, even now, time off after the grueling job of being caregiver.

It was also, it seemed to him, some kind of vindication for his choices, for taking up the job offer in a new industry, moving himself and Madeleine to a new city. She was finding happiness, and nobody could turn around and say Hugo wasn't helping her, wasn't doing everything he could to set her on the right track—even though he'd spent so many weeks since they'd arrived in New York focusing on his own work, his own career.

The main reason he felt so good coming home to an empty apartment, after all, was that he could lay his overwhelming guilt to rest. Madeleine wasn't miserable. He didn't need to feel that irrational anguish any more that it was all his fault.

That, as it turned out, was a huge burden removed from his shoulders.

She only occasionally invited him out to meet her co-workers, but that early on, he avoided her invitations and she didn't seem at all put out. Was he lazy, wanting to put off his entrance into her new circle? He saw it more as wanting to enjoy that personal space he now had. And, not insignificantly, wanting her to have her own independence in bonding with her co-workers.

She'd usually be back before bedtime, to startle him a little with the brevity of her skirts or the depth her necklines plunged, impress him with her energy, dazzle him with her pretty smiles and wide eyes. And he adored it when she regaled him with stories of people he didn't know, who bore names like Jennifer, Dan, Ryan, Fabian, Sasha—all signs she was immersing herself in normality.

She'd enchant him, entice him, tease him with her new self, and yet he found himself completely unable to make a move on her, to act on his lust. Afraid, he thought, of pressuring her if she wasn't ready, though also no doubt terrified of possible rejection, even after all these years together.

It all seemed perfectly reasonable and logical to him every time he thought about it, that he should simply confront the woman he loved, tell her he wanted to tear off her clothes, kiss her all over her body, thrust inside her.

Yet when it came to it, and she was right there in front of him, he felt awkward, stupid, blocked. It just didn't seem right to lay it on her if she wasn't in the right place for it. It felt as though they were now only best friends, not lovers.

So he didn't. He left it, and then he was waking up in the middle of the night to find her tending to herself, and it drove him wild.

Three

One Wednesday morning in February, Hugo found himself really struggling to get up, the recent cold weather getting to him, making his joints ache, making him think about calling in his first sick day in the new job though it was far from strictly necessary.

Madeleine was not only awake, but apparently already in the shower as he reached for the alarm clock to confirm it was his usual time to haul himself out of bed.

He waited, unsure of the reasons for her change of schedule.

When she came out of the bathroom, the light streaming out behind her, she was wearing nothing but a pair of simple black boy short panties, looking stunning.

“Oh, hey you’re up,” she said, and he assumed she meant awake though a double entendre would have been appropriate.

“I am,” he said, rubbing the last vestiges of sleep from his eyes.

She reached into the closet, which took up the entire wall of the bedroom opposite the windows, and withdrew some kind of silky dress that was a blaze of purple, black and white.

“You can tell me how I look,” she said, putting her hands through the sleeves of the dress then pulling it up her arms, over her head and down over her body.

His morning wood was tingling at the unexpected fashion show, but it wasn’t going to help him distinguish between different outfits. She looked incredible in whatever. Had she lost a little weight while he hadn’t been looking?

“You look pretty amazing,” he said, eyes wide, noting that she wasn’t wearing a bra underneath this dress. It still had the tag on it, poking out from the front.

The dress molded around her breasts, her nipples pushing proudly out through the thin black material, then it flared out lower down, bursting into white flowers and purple as it reached her hips and thighs. Sexy, though more like a geisha's kimono than business attire.

"Nice," he said, nodding his appreciation as she turned up the bedroom lights a little to see herself more clearly in the mirrors that adorned the whole closet door—and therefore the whole back wall of the bedroom.

Madeleine did look sensational, her long, as-yet unbrushed golden hair, streaked with darker tones, fell in waves down her back, mussed from sleep but still adding to her beauty. The seductive curves of her body seemed perfectly designed to drive her husband—and any man, for that matter—crazy with desire, and she was turning and stretching to show them off to maximum affect in the mirror.

She wrinkled her faintly freckled nose, as though attempting to mimic the witch from that 60s sitcom, *Bewitched*— she didn't entirely believe her husband's verdict on the dress.

"It looks like a bathrobe, doesn't it?" she said, ripping the thing off, drawing his eyes to the fact that her nipples were stiff either from the attention or the cool winter's air leaking in through the windows.

"Pretty hot bathrobe," he said, but his judgement wasn't cutting it with her. "What's the occasion? Brunch at the Playboy Mansion?"

She tilted her hips and gave him a "ha-ha" look heavy on the irony.

"A bunch of guys are coming down from Head Office today," she said, pulling a bright scarlet dress from the closet now, laying it up against her front to see how the color worked against her pale complexion. As it happened, it worked very well indeed. "It's a big thing apparently."

She stepped into this one, pulling it up her long, freshly shaved legs. Hugo's eyebrows seemed to rise in sync.

"And you guys have these big meetings in dinner dress?"

She smiled, turning as she pulled the flashy strapless garment up over her bare breasts, to see the thing from various angles as she now reached behind to zip it up.

“They’re taking us out to dinner after work,” she said. “Some restaurant uptown.”

Hugo nodded, one hand subtly slipping between his thighs as he watched his pretty wife tugging the dress this way and that, apparently unhappy with its fit despite the fact that it seemed like a second skin, running all the way down to just above her knee.

Still no bra. The red dress, at least, appeared padded enough around the bust to mask the pinpoints of her nipples, mostly. If he wasn’t so secure in his relationship, he might get a little jealous. As it was, he actually felt proud of her, almost happy that other guys would steal glances at her and be taken aback at her beauty. Such a contrast to how she looked before their move to NYC.

“You’ll certainly take their minds off any dinner conversation in that,” he said, meaning to complement her, but instantly fearing she’d take it the wrong way as soon as the words came out of his mouth.

“Too much?”

He could only shrug at that, though his response to the dress was carefully designed only to echo her own apparent feelings for the thing, not actively change her mind. It was always dangerous to offer his opinion on her outfits. If he was too positive, she assumed he was just trying to make her feel good about herself in a husbandly duty kind of way. If he was too negative he might upset her.

And God, what did he know about dresses? They all looked great on her, and it was nothing much to do with how they were cut, how they fit, what color they were—and everything to do with the confidence in which she presented them.

It was far safer, he found, to try to work out how she felt about a particular outfit, then lend her confidence in her choice.

“Thought so,” she said. Well, the color was a little intense, a touch showy. Perfect for the Oscars.

Gazing in the mirror, Madeleine teased her hair a little, this way and that, as though it might change the perception of her dress. But then down came the zip, revealing those spectacular breasts once again, and the scarlet number was quietly replaced back inside the closet.

Next up, a more simple little black dress, though it had some elegant-looking purple here and there, emphasizing a cross shape in black that ran over her bust to flatter her shape—as though it needed flattering. Once again skin-tight in a silky kind of material, it reached an inch or two further above the knee, while the neckline plunged to show off her cleavage.

She looked delicious, of course, but it was just about professional enough to be almost appropriate for a business dinner.

“That the one?” he asked her.

She nodded, not even really seeking his opinion. It was the dress she’d probably decided on all along.

“You look pretty incredible in it.”

A smile, though only half-meant, as she removed the dress to re-hand ready for the evening. She’d never been entirely happy in a dress, even these days it seemed.

“Thanks, sweetie,” she said quietly, as though his opinion had been in any way constructive.

Finally, she was retrieving a matching black bra from her dresser, reminding him of her apparent intent to go without when she changed for dinner, fanning the flames in his stomach that he realized were mild jealousy after all. She peeled pantyhose up over each shapely leg, making herself look even more devastating to a lust-fueled husband, before adding a pale gray skirt.

Her concerns about wearing a dress seemed incongruous since she’d been wearing such sexy little skirts recently.

The tickle of jealousy inside him almost amused him. It was merely a physical thing, he knew—he'd never had anything but one hundred percent trust in Madeleine—yet his body and its primordial instincts were attempting to sew the seeds of doubt, making the silent allegation that she was going out there to seduce someone from Head Office.

Seeing her dress quietly for work, the strange feelings inside him actually made him reassess Madeleine's expression. He suddenly caught the slight sense that he'd done wrong, he hadn't quite passed her test, if that's what this whole thing had been. Maybe he was being paranoid, but she looked slightly—very slightly—annoyed as an appealing pale lilac blouse went on.

Was he supposed to make some kind of comment disapproving of the shortness of her dresses, their skin-tight nature, the plunging necklines—the lack of a bra?

Was he supposed to come across as the jealous husband? But he'd wanted to portray confidence in her, support. Encouraging her sense of independence, the little risks she might feel she was taking in dressing a little more provocatively than she might have in the past.

Underneath it all, he'd just been a little too dazzled to notice any negative ramifications of her dressing in such a way for a dinner.

Quietly, Hugo sighed.

But now the moment was gone, her tone of voice suggesting she was already moving on: “Oh, hey, I'll probably be pretty late home tonight.”

“Sure, no problem.”

And she was heading out to make her way ludicrously early to the store—no doubt to fix things up before the Big Bosses from Head Office arrived—leaving Hugo regretting his curious inability to communicate with her in the way he wanted.

Honey, you look unbelievably gorgeous. I can't believe the guys from Head Office won't be hitting on you like crazy tonight—but what

can I say, I trust you implicitly.

*

She was late home that night, but then he never minded when she was late home. Sometimes when she came home after he'd gone to bed she'd wake him, but often he'd simply wake in the morning to find her sleeping peacefully, as though nothing had happened at all the previous night, perhaps a mysterious smile on her face hinting at some mischief or other.

This time, however, he was awake when she returned. Insomnia wasn't something with which he was regularly afflicted, but on this occasion his head was a little too full thanks to a major project at work—and perhaps, also, his belief that he'd committed a faux pas by not offering any mildly jealous comments about his wife's outfit for her business dinner.

The cogs whirring inside his head made him toss and turn and avoid any hint of sleep. Shortly past 2 am, Madeleine still hadn't come home. Hugo was about to get up himself to admit defeat in his battle for sleep, maybe head out to the living room couch to watch something on the DVR.

Then he heard the apartment door, and the unmistakable voice of his beloved. Who was she talking to?

He stayed put, figuring she was on the phone. He even pretended he was asleep, thinking he might perhaps pounce on her when she eventually came to bed, give her a surprise before teasing her about how exceedingly late she'd stayed out this time—and wearing that hot dress of hers. Who knew, if she was inebriated enough and in the right mood, maybe something might happen between them.

While he waited there in the darkness, though, Madeleine did not come to bed.

Her phone conversation continued, on and on. A few moments more, and she appeared at the bedroom door, still talking as she peered around it, apparently to check that her husband was asleep.

What was she up to?

“No, it’s not like that,” he heard her whisper.

His ears pricked up, and confusion reigned as he tried to untangle what she might be saying to him—before realizing she was holding a cell phone up to her ear, and not speaking to him at all. He played dead, not wanting to interrupt her call, curious about who she was talking to, what she was talking about while she believed her husband was asleep.

“Don’t!” she hissed. “I’m getting all flushed!”

Hugo felt a jolt of surprise scorch his insides. What was she talking about? He did his best to lie still, to avoid reacting, to make her believe he was fast asleep.

Was that the sound of Lucy’s voice from Madeleine’s phone? Lucy, her best friend and their Maid of Honor. It was a little late for gossiping on the phone, surely.

“Hey, it’s not my fault,” Madeleine said. He could only hear one side of the conversation. “What am I supposed to do if the bookstore’s stuffed with hot guys? Refuse to serve them?”

Hugo felt his heart skip a beat.

Hey, what-what?

Stuffed with hot guys? What was his wife talking about?

“Lucy!” Madeleine gasped into the phone, doing a poor job if she was attempting to avoid waking her husband.

Hugo kept his eyes shut tight and his ears poised to detect any further clue as to what his wife’s conversation was about. With the light behind her, highlighting those sensual curves of hers, and his earlier thoughts about perhaps seducing her when she eventually came to bed, Hugo was naturally a little aroused at her appearance at the door. But his curiosity about her phone conversation now took precedence.

Madeleine stepped back from the bedroom door, apparently satisfied that Hugo was fast asleep, but he could still hear her loud and clear.

“Well what was I supposed to do?” she said. “I can’t ignore him just because he’s hot.”

Hugo caught his breath.

So there was a particular guy she’d been flirting with?

As she withdrew into the living room, Hugo found himself slipping silently out of bed, moving like a sniper to the edge of the doorway—and then beyond, to the hallway and that familiar position where he’d violated her privacy before. The darkness aided him this time: she’d switched off the table lamps in the living room this time.

He felt his heart pounding inside his chest, his breathing becoming increasingly labored as he lurked there, craving more insight. He didn’t want to jump to any conclusions, but this was so unexpected. Madeleine had never shown the slightest enthusiasm for flirting with other guys before—not while they’d been together.

“I know.”

She was gazing out of the window, one hand fumbling with the horizontal slats on the blind as she continued her conversation with her best friend. Lines of light filtering in from the street rippled over her body to accentuate the alluring curves of her topography.

“Well he doesn’t need to know that.”

As understanding a husband as he wanted to be, Hugo couldn’t do anything to avoid the sharp pangs of jealousy in his chest. She was talking about another guy, she was inferring that this was all to be kept hush-hush.

Maybe he was just misinterpreting it. There had to be a completely harmless reality behind whatever it was she was talking about. Still, there were danger signals. Strangely, as he watched her other hand begin to

fiddle with one of the buttons on her shirt, Hugo couldn't help but feel the tickle of arousal.

That was confusing.

She was so extravagant in her beauty, standing there in that short dress, her smooth, shapely legs on show, so much thigh exposed it felt like a whisper of a breeze could reveal her shapely derriere to him.

How could it possibly be hot to think of her flirting with another guy at the bookstore? Or having dinner with co-workers and the Guys From Head Office dressed in something a calendar model might wear tacked to a teenage boy's wall? Wasn't a husband supposed to fly into a jealous rage?

Madeleine hissed into the phone: "Of course it's not."

Arousing or not, at the same time the fact she was discussing some other guy filled his chest with dread. She wouldn't do anything—would she?

God, he should never have neglected her, never have simply left her to it. He should have gone out to meet her new friends. She probably thought he didn't care about her any more, now he had this new job in a big PR firm.

Hovering by the corner just by the kitchen, Hugo was beginning to find it difficult to breathe—or at least breathe without alerting his wife to his wakeful presence. He was terrified even to suspect she might cheat on him, that she'd want to do anything behind his back, that he would lose her. So why was he so stiff down there inside his boxer shorts?

"He's not even my type," Madeleine said. "And there's no way I'm his."

She couldn't stop smiling, her face all aglow as though she were standing in front of her high school locker gossiping with a BFF about her latest crush.

Hugo tried to force himself to keep calm. So his wife had a crush on some guy. What was so bad about that? Everybody has fantasies. So why

did he feel warmth spreading through his chest as he stood there watching her? It wasn't just because she'd slipped a hand over her breast, cupping it, squeezing it gently as she spoke into the phone.

"Oh God, don't. I don't need to do that."

He watched transfixed as she quietly coaxed her breast, her fingers moving under the thin material of her dress. Somehow, it felt good to him that Madeleine was getting back in touch with her sexuality, even if it was another guy who inspired it for now. And as for flirting with him, whoever he was—well, she she deserved a little attention, some recognition that she was a beautiful woman, that she could turn any man's head. She couldn't take any of her husband's compliments seriously these days, after all—he was obliged to say flattering things.

"My therapist said a little light flirting is good for my confidence," she said. "She didn't say I should go further than that."

Hugo felt something click inside his head. The logic fell into place—why she was now feeling so much more confident in life, why her sexual desires had re-awakened alongside it, and maybe also why after so many setbacks, she really seemed to be heading for recovery.

Well, if a more flirtatious Madeleine was better armed to fight her condition, he had to support the whole idea.

"Hugo thinks she's a bit of a quack, but it's really making a difference."

He smiled at that, feeling a warmth inside merely at featuring in his wife's thoughts.

Then his smile evaporated.

"Hey, we have a sex life!"

Hugo managed to avoid gasping.

"He's just stressed at work. We just moved to a new city, right? He's in a completely new job."

So their lack of sex was an issue for her. There was something oddly comforting about knowing that, that maybe she wanted to do something

about it too. But why hadn't she mentioned anything?

"Who knows? Maybe he doesn't find me attractive anymore. But I don't want to put any pressure on him right now. Not after what we've been through."

The cold fingers of despair were clutching at his heart again—was this lack of intimacy between them pushing her to flirt with other guys? Was he losing her? He felt he ought to go straight out there and drag her back into the bedroom, to prove himself. Assert himself. But if he did that, she'd know he'd been overhearing her private conversation.

"You should come down—you'll love it here, I swear."

Madeleine's hand had slipped back out of her dress, but now Hugo watched as it slid slowly down her stomach—then dipped between her thighs.

"At the very least, you'll love the guys down here. New York has plenty of hunky men, Luce."

She was touching herself.

Hugo felt his prick twitch. Remembering the last time he'd seen her touching herself—now it seemed very clear to him that she had, very probably, been thinking about other guys when she'd been doing it. Maybe even a specific other guy.

Why was it hot to think that she was? Was there something wrong with him?

"I promise I won't," Madeleine was saying to her friend, and Hugo couldn't believe what he was seeing. Her phone call hadn't even ended yet.

He could see her battling to maintain a calm voice on the phone, while tending to her burning desire. The way she awkwardly clutched the phone between her ear and shoulder, murmuring affirmative noises to suggest she was listening to Lucy, made him certain her conscious mind was moving elsewhere. She pulled up her dress, revealing that wonderfully curvaceous behind, and her little pair of black lace panties.

She really needed her friend to hang up.

Hugo felt himself short of breath again. His manhood thickening further, tingling as he watched, responding to the irresistible sight of his wife left standing there in full view of their neighbors, her dress hiked up and her hand in her panties.

And then she said something that made Hugo's heart almost seize up.

"Hey, he's home. I see him. Gotta go."

Four

All he could do in that moment was watch.

She brushed her long blonde tresses out of her face, and gazed out of the windows, resting a knee on the cushion in front, leaning forward to peer through the blind at the apartment across the street. She was so graceful, one delicate hand gliding over her body as the other kept apart two of the horizontal slats in the blinds. Every movement was so gradual, as though someone had filmed her and then slowed down the movie.

What was she looking at—who was she looking at?

Was it really the guy she'd been flirting with in the bookstore? Did he live across the street?

Hugo wanted to tear himself away from the doorway, go to the window and see for himself who she was watching. But at the same time he didn't want to miss the sight of his wife if she was going to repeat the last window display he'd witnessed. He just wanted to take in her beauty like some kind of art connoisseur.

All that time she'd spent sitting on that window seat before getting her new job, reading and staring out at the apartments opposite. Had she been watching someone in particular? Building up a crush? At the time, Hugo had been happy she had so many windows to look at while he was at work, but he now realized he had no idea who lived over there, what she might have been watching day in, day out.

Madeleine slipped the straps of her dress over her shoulders, revealing her bare breasts to the world if only it could see her in this darkened apartment. She startled him a little with her sudden near-nudity, not so much from the possibility of being seen from this apartment, but from the idea that she really hadn't been wearing much during her business dinner, or whatever else had kept her out until two.

Jealousy and fear burned bright within him at the apparent confirmation she'd been lusting after someone else, and might be doing so now.

And yet he could not deny just how exciting this was, how thrilling to observe her sexuality unleashed—the way she moved when she was genuinely turned on, free from any fear of judgment from her husband. He was so hard as he watched her.

Curiosity ultimately helped him tear himself away from the vision in their living room to tiptoe quietly back into the bedroom, to see who it was his wife was watching.

That late, only a smattering of apartments across the street had lights on. Only a few, as far as Hugo could see, offered a view of actual people.

She had to be watching the guys directly across. College students—or at least, they appeared to be. For a moment, Hugo thought they might even be high school students, they looked so young. But they had that air of nonchalant self-confidence that couldn't come from high school. If they were college students, then they were wealthy ones, or trust fund babies, to be able to live over there. Reminded Hugo of that TV show Madeleine had liked to watch, *Gossip Girl*. Impossibly good-looking students living impossibly glamorous lives.

Their apartment, like all of those across the street, offered high ceilings and large windows. Furnished with designer-looking trappings of affluence, probably regularly cleaned by a professional cleaner, this was not the squalor Hugo remembered from his own college days.

He couldn't tell who owned the place, or even who lived there. Five guys lounged around on couches and armchairs, a few girls. Looking as though a party was coming to an end, they were all sipping wine or beers in glasses, rather than cans or bottles. Talking, smoking, laughing, care-free.

Which guy was Madeleine watching? They all looked well groomed, wearing smart clothes and with trim figures. The blond one? The dark-haired guy? The Asian guy? One of the two guys who looked like twins, but probably weren't even related?

It was so easy to see into that apartment, to watch everything that went on. What had she seen in there over those weeks and months? It was kind of hot to think of her catching sight of illicit scenes, being so naughty in her voyeurism. Hugo looked at the college guys, at how young they seemed, and he actually smiled. Madeleine could dream of them all she liked, maybe even more than one of them. Somehow it was reassuring that they were so young—as though the age gap confirmed he could never lose her to them.

What would her family and friends think, if she shacked up with someone ten years younger?

Quietly pleased, he returned to the bedroom doorway, and then after a moment monitoring the situation for risk, he crept back out to the end of that little hallway, and the corner by the kitchen.

He could see she'd sunk down onto the cushioned window seat—sitting in that now-familiar position up against the far wall. For a moment Hugo worried that she'd spot him watching her, that she'd be angry at him. But she didn't notice him at all, he remained in the shadows. She seemed to be in something of a daze now—no longer so concerned about the threat of being caught.

So beautiful sitting there in her underwear, both hands sweeping over her body as she settled into a stable, comfortable position. Her legs parted so that she was almost sitting cross-legged, leaning back against the wall, her hands now trailing up her thighs to find the center of her womanhood, and glide over the thin black lace covering it.

Hugo felt such an urge to go to her, to join her, to indulge in her beauty—to taste her, breathe her in, ravage her. But as had been the case

all through her depression, he felt that invisible barrier blocking his way—paranoia, anxiety, fear of rejection.

In the still darkness, he caught the subtle but irresistibly sensuous sound of his pretty wife's heavy breathing, with those elegant hands of hers gliding over her heaving chest, up to sweep her hair out of her face, diverting it to flow down one side of her head.

The way she had slats in the blinds angled now, she had to believe she was safe from others looking in on her, though she could watch her new Romeo across the street. She was so brazen, jutting out her chest, her breasts so pert and full, her nipples impossibly hard. Hugo had to stifle a moan of his own as she pushed her pale, creamy breasts together and fondled those prominent little rosy buds, uttering a quiet gasp as her fingers grazed over her sensitive flesh.

There was no way he could disturb her and get away with it now. The way his quiet throbbing hard-on strained to be touched, if he went out now it would be quite clear to her that he'd been watching her for a while.

And anyway, he wanted to watch her, wanted to see. He felt vulnerable clinging to that exposed corner, but there was no alternative. Each moment he let her lie there and continue her wanton display he felt the tension edge up a notch, the risk, the danger, the potential for anger when eventually she did discover him. But he could not pull himself away. Hugo had to force himself to keep calm, breathe deeply, remain silent.

Madeleine was absolutely breathtaking.

Maybe if he continued watching, he'd learn a little something about how to give her pleasure.

Hugo could hear Madeleine's deep breathing almost as easily as his own now, as he saw her slip a hand under the waistband of her little panties. In the still of the night, even with the faint traffic hum from far off, he could hear the whisper of her fingers running over her skin.

He couldn't help himself, couldn't avoid quietly slipping his hard cock out of his fly as he watched her tuck her thumbs into her panties, and gently lift her hips to draw them out from under her, slide the scrap of black lace slowly up her divinely rounded thighs, over her knees, down her calves and away.

She looked like a goddess bathed in the horizontal lines of streetlight, and watching her made Hugo want to bow down and worship her.

Madeleine turned her head to look out of the window again. Her gaze into the glass was so knowing, so self-confident, so raunchy. She was beautiful, powerful, irresistibly sexual, and he was enthralled by the sight of her peach-soft flesh unclothed and unrestrained.

Was she getting off on her display? It almost seemed that she was playing with the idea of being seen, though with the cover of darkness and the shield-like blind keeping her safe. Safe, but then something about being there in the window, the risk that somebody might actually see—that excited her. Hugo felt a ripple of pleasant surprise at being sure of it.

Madeleine had never mentioned any exhibitionist fantasies before. Come to think of it, she'd never revealed any real fantasies before, period. She was something of a mystery, even after so long as his wife. He was pleased she was exploring her desires like this—it had to be healthy given what she'd been through, relieving her tension. Even if he wasn't involved at this stage.

God, she was so sexy.

Madeleine moved her knees over towards her husband, keeping the juiciest sight of her personal area away from any onlookers across the street, but in so doing offering it all up to Hugo, who had just enough light to see between her thighs, catch the little golden dusting of hair pointing to her treasure.

Hugo had to be careful to maintain his self-control as her hand slipped over her stomach and over her mound, her graceful fingers

applied to her tender folds and sensitive clit like those of a concert pianist laid on the ivories and ebonies.

Madeleine moaned long and low as her fingertips began to slide over her moistened lips, and strum her aching button.

Her husband watched while gently stroking his rigid shaft, his breathing growing shallow and rapid as though it was difficult to absorb the oxygen from the air. He was suffocating from the raw sexuality of his exquisite wife. It was the most thrilling sensation he could remember.

He felt his guilt melting away as he watched her. It made him feel out-and-out wonderful—almost above the rampant excitement she inspired in him from her physical display. To see her cry out and arch her back as a torrent of sexual energy rushed through her sweeping curves, gave him the impression she was finding release even though he as her husband was failing her.

Her orgasm was exquisite, the sight of her quivering like that, trembling at the sheer power of the feelings swamping her system, shocking and delighting him. The sweet sound of her plaintive cry at just how glorious she felt.

Hugo kept himself back from the edge of his own climax, his attention on her, wanting to enjoy the moment without being distracted by his own messy orgasm. Then he realized the moment was over, and unless he made himself scarce, she would find him there in a humiliating state.

He slipped back away from the door, back to bed and safety. Heard her enter the bedroom, going into the bathroom. Lying there, he managed to make his heavy breathing seem like quiet snoring, as he played the sleeping husband once again.

When she came to lie with him, he could smell soap and moisturizer rather than that dark scent of female arousal. It was faintly disappointing, but at least he could still smell that unmistakable sweetness that didn't

really come from any one product or fragrance, that aroma that was characteristically her.

It drove him wild, and he had to lie on his front so that she wouldn't accidentally brush against his erection, giving the game away.

Five

Hugo found it hard to concentrate at work the next day, his head replaying every moment from the night before, particularly the conversation Madeleine had had with Lucy. For the sake of his sanity, he had to assume from her side of the conversation that his wife had been resisting any suggestions from her best friend that she would actually cheat on him.

But it had been eye-opening that she apparently thought he wasn't ready for sex—that this was the issue keeping them from reengaging after their long hiatus.

I don't want to put any pressure on him right now, she'd said.

The same excuse he gave for not initiating anything with her, she was embracing herself, only with roles reversed.

Was there something in what she'd said? Did he need time?

She was the one attending regular therapy sessions. Perhaps she was having professional analysis done on him by proxy. And Dr. Simeon's analysis suggested he wasn't ready for sex.

The other eye-opener Madeleine had dropped into her conversation with her best friend had been the professional recommendation that she flirt with men around her. Hugo couldn't help dwelling on that point while he was supposed to be fashioning a press release about the launch of a limited edition sneaker.

Madeleine had been enjoying flirtatious encounters with other men—all perfectly innocent, from what she'd said. But what was flirtation? The dictionary of Google defined it as “behavior that demonstrates a playful sexual attraction to someone”.

So Madeleine was demonstrating her playful sexual attraction to other men.

There was something both uncomfortable and deeply erotic about that idea. It made him feel both slightly queasy and powerfully aroused. At the end of the day, the arousal added to his sense of discomfort, purely because it was so shocking that the thought of Madeleine hinting at attraction to other men made him feel in any way good.

She was his wife. He wasn't supposed to casually embrace knowledge of her making eyes at other men, no matter how controlled and limited her intentions were with them.

And she was certainly sexually attracted to them – to at least one of them, the man who lived across the street. One of the college students, Hugo's deductions had suggested. She had sat there in the windows on God-alone-knew-how-many nights and watched him while stroking herself to orgasm.

Why did that all seem so exciting to Hugo? Was it some kind of mental shield set up by his brain to protect itself from the expectation of imminent pain? Like the shock that cushions a trauma victim from the pain of a serious injury. His body was protecting his mental state from the prospect of his wife cheating on him by turning the idea into a bizarre fantasy.

Underlying his own personal exhilaration at this divergent behavior of his wife, was the revelation that her flirting was part of her treatment regime, it would appear. A treatment regime, Hugo noted, which had had more of a success in tackling her debilitating condition than any other.

By the end of the working day, Hugo felt resolved to support Madeleine's illicit flirtations, if only in the name of her continuing to succeed with her treatment. If he happened to enjoy the thought that she was giving herself little sexual thrills in doing so, then that was merely a happy coincidence. Maybe when he finally got up the courage to just initiate sex with her, the feelings coursing through his veins might help him sustain his performance and prevent the kind of sexual disasters that had happened while they'd been in the middle of their dark period.

“Coming out, Hugo?”

Hugo looked up from his desk to see the imposing form of his colleague Lowego Mars. Jesus. Had he spoken his thoughts aloud? Blurted his terrible secret? Would Lowego tell everybody, was he going to be a laughing stock for ever more at this company?

The man who gets off on his wife flirting with other men.

“Huh?” he said, startled, dazed.

Lowego smiled. “We’re going out for a drink or two – remember? To celebrate.”

Hugo heaved a huge sigh of relief. Secret safe. The sales team had won a big contract – a bunch of the guys were going out to the nearby Polish bar, and then according to some, a strip club, which seemed oddly incongruent with the image of this PR company as a slick 21st Century bastion of political correctness.

“Oh, right. Yeah—I’ll come for a few. Can’t stay out too late, though,” he said, quashing any disappointment in Lowego in advance that there was no way he was going to any strip club.

“Know exactly what you mean,” the big bearded man smiled, holding up a hand to show off his own wedding ring in some kind of sense of solidarity.

Hugo returned his smile, nodded. “Maybe another night, when she’s out with her friends...”

“Maybe when we’ve flown to the other side of the country to seal a contract, and we’re not expected back at all,” he laughed.

It irritated Hugo slightly, that he couldn’t go home until later on this particular night, when he felt so very anxious about what he had to say to Madeleine. He just wanted to get home, get it over with.

He texted Madeleine to let her know he was going to be late, he wasn’t sure what time he’d be home. She’d been hounding him to do this kind of thing anyway. To bond with his own co-workers, perhaps form a few friendships.

> Hey honey, that's fine—I'm on the late shift tonight anyway, remember?

Her reply brought mild consolation: he wouldn't be able to talk to her about anything anyway until much later. Perhaps a few drinks in the mean time would give him the heart to say what he needed to say to her.

*

Sitting in a Midtown bar after work, he found his thoughts drifting elsewhere as his colleague George Ray recounted his latest conquest—he didn't even hear who it was this time—the intern in accounts receivable, the redhead executive from Marmaduke's Cookies, the hooker who offered to share his cab on the way back to the hotel in Detroit?

“It's the newness,” he explained, in one of the few conversations with Ray that ever made an impression on Hugo. “Strange pussy. It makes you feel alive, you know? Like, I ain't ever gonna love someone else—so it's not really cheating, right?”

“But you don't tell Shona about any of it.” Hugo acting the journalist one more time, throwing the curveball.

“She wouldn't understand. See, some women—a lot of women—can't sleep with a guy without it turning into this emotional mess. So they assume we're the same, right?”

“Maybe, some of them.”

“But, see, for us, it's just sex, right? Two people rubbing up against each other a little, you know? I go home after, and she knows I love her'n the kids. I probably would be tempted, you know, to leave, if I didn't get that strange.”

Hugo had to be diplomatic, nod and smile, because Ray had been the one that got him the job, encouraged him down to the Big Apple, doubled his pay check. He couldn't show disapproval for what Ray felt

like disclosing after a few JD and cokes while the piano tinkled away in the background.

“You think she’d tell you to stop, if she ever found out?”

“I guess,” he sniffed. He normally didn’t like to talk about Shona when they were at a bar. “Hell, she probably doesn’t even care. Stopped thinking about anything to do with sex long, long ago.”

“Maybe she’s getting some strange while you’re at work.”

Ray laughed at that. As though it wasn’t even a remote possibility.

“If she understood it was just like scratching an itch, and then I’m done and it’s back to real life, maybe I would tell her,” he said. “But if I told her and she said stop, that might be the thing that killed our marriage, you know? ‘Cause why should loving someone have to mean never experiencing the real pleasures of life ever again?”

Hugo couldn’t help thinking about this philosophy of Ray’s on the way home. From his perspective, it quickly turned on its head, becoming a question of whether he had been preventing Madeleine from experiencing the real pleasures of life. He knew these feelings were driven by the guilt he’d borne for the year years of Madeleine’s depression. That she might be better off with someone else, that another guy would keep her so happy, she wouldn’t even need treatment. He’d read up on it, he knew it was merely psychological transference, but that guilt remained nevertheless.

Was Madeleine feeling the same temptation to experience life that Ray had apparently felt most of his marriage? Had she been thinking of ‘strange’ while sitting on that window seat late at night? Imagining the thrill of somebody different, the buzz of dating again?

There was something very attractive about the idea of Madeleine being allowed to experience life, for some reason. It pandered to his feelings of guilt, but it also played on his very real need for her to be happy, to feel good, to be sexually satisfied.

*

Hugo had two drinks too many at the bar, partly out of the sense that he was fortifying himself in preparation for a Heavy conversation with Madeleine in which he might or might not accidentally let slip knowing that she was flirting with other men in order to help with her recovery.

He swayed a little on his walk back to the subway.

He wasn't used to drinking a lot. He didn't go out socially much at all, and during his months and years taking care of Madeleine, he'd been embroiled in some kind of self-imposed Prohibition. At least he'd managed to prize himself away from the others before they'd gone on to the strip club.

He was shaking, all the way home. Uncertain what he was going to say to her, nervous that he would make her angry. Terrified that if he played it wrong, it might destroy any hope of her full recovery. He was also nervous that misplaced words might make her stop this new flirtatiousness. And as much as he thought about that, he never thought that he wanted it to stop.

Hugo got off the subway a stop early, hoping the extra burst of night air might help him burn off some of the alcohol before he got home. It was a few blocks away from the station that he realized his route would take him close to Madeleine's bookstore.

His strategy seemed almost fully formed as soon as it entered his head. Swinging by the bookstore, perhaps trying to see for himself what Madeleine was like with her co-workers and customers, keeping himself hidden. It was a bad plan—he knew that much. Creepy. Stalkerish. Grounds for divorce.

But here he was, a slave to curiosity. His heart-rate picking up as he diverted off the direct route home, Hugo decided it had to be a positive thing: it wasn't that he didn't trust Madeleine to keep her flirting under control. He wanted to see it.

To know she was flirting with other men was one thing, but to see it actually happening—that would help him to ascertain how he really felt.

*

It was just gone 9 pm by the time he reached the store. The darkness of night was complete, though the street lighting didn't offer much by way of shadow to cover Hugo as he hovered across the street. All he could do was put his cell phone up to his face and make up fake conversations whenever anyone came near him on the street.

A call to a fake mother concerned at her fake son never coming round to visit her at her fake house in fake Brooklyn seemed to do the trick.

God, he felt like such a stalker. That same mixture of exhilaration and shame as when he'd been watching her personal time on the window seat.

Madeleine would be livid if she realized what he was doing.

But he couldn't help himself. He had to know what she was up to at work, he had to check she was okay, that she was safe—but he also had to satisfy his curiosity and that weird burning lust. So here he was lurking on a street corner, peering across at the bookstore while chattering to a made-up parent.

There she was.

A burst of heat erupted from Hugo's heart as he laid eyes on her, shimmering in between the bookshelves and sales tables like some kind of siren. That golden hair tied up in a loose bun that gave her the sweet girl-next-door look. She was wearing dark pants for once, which amused Hugo in that he found he was surprised she wasn't flashing around one of her new teeny-tiny skirts.

Yet even from across the street he saw that her pants were tight enough to offer a tantalizing idea of the shape of her legs. Her top was

sleeveless, a blend of various shades of blue. Refined, and yet cut so that it appeared to show off her cleavage to maximum effect.

She looked elegant, and yet still sexy. Moving from here to there, she was drawing the eyes of male customers with her, which made Hugo feel a hint of excitement and jealousy.

Even from this distance, he could see that dazzling smile breaking out as she glanced at a co-worker, or spoke to a customer. What was she saying to them?

He crossed the street, eyes darting this way and that, though the traffic was light at that time of night.

From the store window, he could conceal himself behind a poster to avoid Madeleine's detection while making it appear that he was checking out the window display. From this distance, she seemed to be the picture of innocence—and yet with an edge of seduction that Hugo could see getting under the skins of her customers.

He smiled as he watched them sneaking surreptitious glances at her. The 50-something professorial guy who entered the shop and just stopped to look at her as though he recognized her and couldn't place her name.

They all wanted her. Hugo teemed with pride and lust. Men circling her like sharks around a raft.

Madeleine herself seemed to have something of a glow about her, and she never seemed to stop moving. Talking to this guy or that guy. Helping her co-workers point out where this title or that title could be found.

From what he could see, Hugo was reassured to some degree—she was only doing this for fun, not actually to pick up any of the guys. But the looks she gave those customers brave enough to go up to her, and the way she edged in on their personal space, made it look so real that she was actually interested in them. She was having fun—it must turn her on,

Hugo thought. Is she imagining being with them when she leads them innocently on?

They were certainly imagining being with her.

Hugo slipped inside the store, finding a corner where he could stake out a subtle presence away from any meddling store staff.

The store was quite large—in this day an age of Amazon, a book store had to be, he supposed. Though it was so marvelously convenient to shop for books online—and read them electronically—it was a shame that places like this were dying out. The atmosphere was so warm and inviting, with its relaxed lighting, the occasional potted plants, the easy chairs welcoming readers into their open arms.

It was, as he had hoped, the perfect place for someone to recover from stress, from pain, from melancholy.

Hugo monitored Madeleine, but managed to keep from being seen by her as she sidled up to a tall Latino man standing behind the checkout desk.

He couldn't hear what she was saying to him, but she was immediately smiling as she approached him, one hand on her waist as though to help push out her chest, her shoulders pushed back to emphasize her feminine shape. She looked up at him as though she really admired him, and it sent a jolt of burning jealousy through Hugo's chest.

And yet, he did not dislike it. The feeling inside him, the bite, the squeeze, as he saw her giggling at something the guy said, flicking back rogue strands of hair to subconsciously point his gaze toward her face—it was like the bittersweet tang of a very fine wine. He could appreciate the conflicting sensations swirling around inside him to watch her engage with this faintly intimidating rival. The guy was not only tall, but appeared effortlessly powerful under a button-down white shirt and dark pants. He oozed cool charm, but concealed the kind of athleticism that might cause a shiver or two in women around him, while gaining instant respect from the men.

He saw the way Madeleine jinked her hip, tilted her head, casually stroked her collarbone. Was it really so innocent, the way she was with this guy?

The Latino guy was happy enough to edge into her personal space, and when he did so, she did not pull away. Smiled, as though encouraging it. Hugo found all the eye contact between them breathtaking. They were stripping off each others' clothes with their gazes.

She gently brushed his forearm while making a point. A few moments later, he was touching hers as though explaining something to her, reassuring her about something. God, it was like open adultery going on right in front of his eyes.

And yet, she hadn't done anything wrong. No divorce court in the land would take this as grounds.

She leaned up to whisper in his ear, and her Latino friend stooped to hear what she was saying, clearly drawing a chestful of her perfume, his eyes firmly focused down her shirt.

Did Hugo see Madeleine shiver just a little? God, she really was feeling it for this guy.

But then she was walking away again, and neither of them were looking at the other—not a single last lingering look, or a glance over the shoulder. As though this kind of encounter happened every day, it was nothing significant.

Hugo let out his breath. Jesus.

"D'you need some help, sir?" A young woman, maybe 25-ish, with long mousey hair and the kind of short skirt and hose combination that made Hugo suspect she might have been influenced in her fashion choice by a certain new co-worker. This would be "Sasha" according to the brassy pin on her lapel.

"Uh... no, thank you."

"We close at 10."

“Sure... I mean, I know.”

“Let me know if you need any help, huh?”

“I’ll do that.”

The way she smiled at him, the way she attempted to get close to him, the way she dressed—it reminded Hugo of Madeleine’s new persona, made him wonder if it was some kind of store policy to have staff flirting with customers in order to maximize sales, or whether this was merely a young girl’s admiration for a slightly older co-worker who clearly had every male in the room under her spell.

The bookstore was getting fairly empty by now, and Hugo was feeling more and more vulnerable hovering there in his corner.

If he was discovered, he didn’t have much explanation other than to suggest he’d been on the way home, and thought he’d drop by to take a look at her store, but didn’t want to disturb her at work.

For a moment, he thought he saw her glance his way—but then another customer drew her away.

She was so good with them, so engaged in their conversation, flattering in her apparent interest. Playing with her hair a little while she listened to them, never failing with the eye contact.

“You could definitely be an actor,” she said to the young guy now. “You have that look.”

He could see her reaching up the shelves to retrieve something for the guy—two books, actually. Showing off her curves to her customer, who wasn’t bashful in his appreciation.

“I’m buying something for my girl,” he was saying as she scouted out another title for him. “She read that book, you know, the dirty one.”

Madeleine’s giggle cut Hugo to the bone, but made him throb between the thighs.

“*Fifty Shades of Grey*, huh?” she said. “We have more like that in the back. Top shelf over there.”

The guy trying it on. “You want to show me which ones’re any good?”

Hugo feeling certain the old Madeleine would have laughed off his suggestion, dodged the rest of the conversation.

New Madeleine saying, with that flirtatious lilt: “Sure, I’ll show you. Just don’t tell my husband I read ‘em.”

Going off with the guy to pick out some erotica titles—Hugo was a little taken aback, but then he guessed it was simply more sales she was attracting. Kind of sweet she mentioned her husband as a way of cooling down the flirtation.

A few minutes later that guy was leaving the store with a truckload of books.

Hugo was actually thinking about slipping away, leaving her to it. Then he saw her appear from the back of the store, and flash a glare his way.

Damn.

He froze to the spot, his head spinning as he scratched for the pre-planned explanation he’d concocted but now entirely forgotten regarding how he came to be lurking in her bookstore like this, without letting her know he was there.

Hugo involuntarily took a step back, edging in closer to the bookshelves as though he might be able to blend in with the rows of multi-colored spines, of disappear within the pages of the books. To his surprise, Madeleine’s annoyed gaze did not follow him.

He glanced to the side, and saw another man breeze into the store as though he owned it—and realized quickly that Madeleine’s acid glare was reserved for this guy. She still hadn’t seen Hugo.

Hugo smiled to himself, but looked away briefly to check he was not being observed by anyone else in the store. Reassured of his safety, he resumed his stakeout. Madeleine had apparently turned her back on the newcomer, to fill out some kind of paperwork over at the checkout

counter. She wasn't skipping over to flirt with him and point him to all number of interesting volumes as she had been doing with other customers in the place all night.

Hugo edged around the bookshelves to see if he could get a little closer without being spotted. Easier done than said, since she'd turned her back on the front of the store.

Taking up fresh position daringly within earshot, he watched the stylish-looking young gentleman saunter up to the counter to stand beside Madeleine. He was probably late twenties, tall and strong, with a bearing and outfit that suggested that he was moneyed.

"Hello."

"Hi."

No smile from Madeleine. She didn't even look up from her paperwork. Just an awkward greeting. Did she know this guy? Was he someone who had irritated her in some way?

"Can I help you?" Her voice was cutting, not flirty.

The man, whoever he was, was not put off. He stood there with his hands in the pockets of his tailored-yet-understated dark jacket, and said: "I just came to flirt with you a little at work. That is allowed in book store rules?"

He had a deep, seemingly cultured voice. Confident, masculine.

"I don't know," she said.

Hugo edged around and saw the man from the side, his dark brooding eyes, the long black hair that swirled up in a nonchalant quiff not unlike an early Elvis—a guy needed real self-belief to pull off this kind of look.

Madeleine seemed to bristle in his presence, and it amused Hugo, though he found himself on guard in case he needed to step in to protect his wife on any account. Her new flirtatious attitude might give her a buzz, but there was always the risk that she'd draw the wrong kind of

man. She could turn out to be the bait that lures the predator instead of the decent catch.

“You always seem pretty good at it,” he said.

“I don’t mean to be rude,” that sharp tone of hers again. It fair made a man wince. “If you’re not going to be buying books right now, I have customers to serve.”

She gave a flick of her hair and walked away from the brooding man, who was perhaps a few years younger than her, though old enough to target her.

“You’ve been thinking about me, haven’t you?” the man said as he casually followed her.

She paused, glanced over her shoulder, offering him a sigh and an eye-roll. “Why are you following me?”

A shrug from the young pretender. “My father always told me to follow my dream.”

Hugo coughed to stifle an escaped chuckle. Attempting a line like that, you had to hand it to the guy.

“This is how you think you’ll get me to have a drink with you?” she said, turning to look at him with pity in her eyes. “You usually have much luck approaching women like this?”

“I’ve never had to before.”

“Right, they just flock to your banner.”

The guy paused, nodded, said: “You’re curious about my banner. I suppose it’s only natural.”

Another eye-roll from Madeleine. Hugo was enjoying this show, though it wasn’t along the lines of the flirting he’d hoped to witness. Call it the down side of her getting in touch with her sexy side.

“One of these days, you will tell me your name,” he said. “And you will make me a very happy man.”

Hugo was slightly confused. Didn’t all of the bookstore staff have their names prominently displayed on buttons. Hello my name is Ryan.

Hello my name is Jennifer. Hello my name is Dan. Hello my name is... Madeleine had been wearing hers earlier, but must have removed it the moment this young cavalier had arrived.

“Why do you come here, you never buy books?” she said now.

“Talking to you is my favorite part of the day.”

She was blushing, and Hugo sensed that she wanted to knock this guy’s teeth out—but she was doing supremely well to keep her calm. Quietly, Hugo made the judgement that she was perfectly adept at holding her own, and that this young guy with his hair and his refined dress sense probably wasn’t a real threat. He turned and slipped out of the store, thinking it a good time to escape before she noticed him.

He’d seen enough. She was bright, chirpy, sexy, in her new flirtatious attitude—and it had been a complete turn-on to see her like this. But she was maintaining her cool, she knew where the line in the sand was. Oddly, that felt faintly disappointing to Hugo.

That evening, there hadn’t been any sign of any of those college students who lived across the street from their apartment—but then what were the chances that the half-hour Hugo would actually be at the book store, Madeleine’s crush would also be there?

Six

On the way home, and then waiting for her to come home, he was thinking about how she'd been with that Latin man. Was he her boss? He had carried himself with an air of authority. Was she drawn to his power, this air of confidence in a tall, strong, dark-haired, tan-skinned demigod of the bookstore?

If he chose to show her some attention, would she be tempted by him?

Watching him towering over her, the way she seemed to melt in his presence, her smiles free and easy with lots of teeth and eyes and flicks of the hair. Was she imagining what it might be like to have such a tree-trunk of a man between her thighs?

Hugo shivered at the thought, his heart all a flutter.

He wasn't a small man himself, though he appeared decidedly average in that man's presence, and Madeleine had seemed downright small. Hugo wondered if the man's darker complexion appealed to her, since her husband was pale and mousey. His obvious physicality, his easy charm, the clear difference from Hugo's averageness, his middle-of-the-road normality, it all caused little ripples of jealousy in him as he watched her in his presence. Was she craving someone so obviously different from her husband?

Was it dangerous for her to continue flirting with him? Not only physically, but since he was her boss? She'd go too far one day, and then if she ever stopped him, told him *no*, he might decide he could tolerate her coquettish attitude in the store no longer.

By that time, if that time came, Madeleine would have pulled clear of her depression, and established enough of a resurgent resumé to quickly find something else.

Of course, the other question was whether time and familiarity, perhaps along with an after-work drink here, or a late-night shift there, would actually weaken Madeleine's resolve to say *no* at all when the time came. That was the issue that really made Hugo's heart flutter.

When Madeleine came home, Hugo already knew he didn't have the energy to start a Big Conversation about everything that was on his mind. No, far better to wait until their anniversary, when the usual dinner conversation might provide the one-on-one focus needed to get everything he was feeling out in the open.

When Madeleine came home, she was also far too bubbly and cheerful for her husband to want to risk starting a We-Have-To-Talk heavy discussion.

She came in for a hug, swamping him with that sexy cherry-vanilla scent of hers, something he recalled from their earliest dating days, but which hadn't surfaced since. Strangely, he found himself edging his hips back, so she couldn't feel his hardness pressing against her. Maybe that therapist was right, if that was what she'd said. Maybe he wasn't ready.

He'd be ready after their anniversary dinner.

"What is it?" he laughed. "I mean, I know we haven't seen each other since morning, but..."

"The guys from head office said *yes*!" she exclaimed, as though he knew exactly what she was talking about.

"That's great, honey!"

"They want us to try the first one a week next Thursday."

"First one?" he couldn't conceal his ignorance much further.

"You know, my book-signing event. Well, it's not really just a book signing, really more like an author workshop."

"Fantastic. And you came up with that?"

"I pitched it to Fabian, and he contacted head office," she said, grinning from ear to ear. "It's what they came down to talk to us about, you know?"

“The big meeting. Well, it all sounds absolutely awesome, hon.”

He was genuinely pleased that she was achieving things with her new job, that they were taking her ideas seriously at the store. Something about what she said triggered some small alarm inside his head... but he couldn't quite figure out what... Ah.

“You do realize next Thursday's our five-year anniversary?”

She paused, and he saw surprise passing through her face that she'd forgotten the importance of the date. Usually it was him that forgot these things.

“Oh my God, I'm so sorry,” she said, her eyes widening at her marital faux pas. “Would you be heart-broken if we did something another time? Call that our anniversary? I promise I'll make it up to you.”

He'd shrugged and said of course, no problem. It would give him a little more time, perhaps, to prepare what he needed to say to her to get all this baggage out once and for all.

“It's kind of too late to move the event now,” she said. “The publicity's gone out...”

“Of course,” Hugo said, sounding a touch more dejected than he meant to, in order to try to emphasize the point that this year it was her forgetting their important date, not him.

Madeleine took his response as straightforward disappointment for her forgetting the date. “I swear, we'll do something really nice instead—weekend after, right?”

“Sure,” he said. “It'll be nice.”

Now that he thought about it, he was quietly pleased they were missing their anniversary for another reason—because Madeleine was organizing an event, thinking outside the box, making the most of her first step back into the employment pool.

He was seriously proud of her.

“You want me to come on Thursday?”

“Oh, you don’t have to,” she said. He couldn’t quite read whether she really wanted him to attend, but didn’t want to force him, or if she was subtly trying to encourage him not to attend because it was the first of these events and she would be nervous.

“I’ll see what my schedule looks like,” he said, keeping his tone noncommittal.

“It’ll be kind of like a trial one, this one, so probably a little rough ‘round the edges anyway.”

Hugo nodded, smiled what he hoped was a reassuring smile. “I’m sure it will be really good.”

He’d be more than a little out of his depth at a book-signing event, anyway. Mixing with people who probably knew who the author was, and expected him to as well. He was fairly sure it would be one less element of stress for her during the event if her husband wasn’t there, and on deciding not to go to this one, he saw a note of relief in her understanding smile. Maybe it was best for both of them if he gave it a miss.

“I’ll come to the next one,” he said, and she gave him the kind of expression that instantly told him he’d taken the right approach.

That night, he stayed awake long into the small hours, reviewing and re-reviewing the sight of his pretty wife batting her eyelids at that tall man at the checkout desk. Was he Fabian, the man she had pitched her idea to, who had the hotline to head office to make these things happen just like that? No wonder she had eyes for him.

He half wondered if she might feel so good from her success, not to mention her day’s brush with the tall Latino guy, she might get up in the middle of the night once again to relieve her pressure in that most beautiful of ways.

He wanted to see Madeleine tearing off her clothes, he wanted to see her pleasuring herself in the way he wanted to with her, but for some

reason could not. Did he also want to judge whether she might be thinking about Fabian while she did so?

Whatever, she remained asleep that night, and the few nights after that.

*

Thursday, the night of her event. He didn't mind staying home once he'd returned from work on that particular night. Putting his feet up, tucking into a Domino's pizza in front of *Mad Men*—it turned out to be a very relaxing and enjoyable anniversary evening, with the notable exception that Madeleine wasn't there.

Sitting in front of the TV, he felt a contented buzz at the knowledge that his smart, beautiful wife was out there achieving things all evening. Handling authors, fans, and no doubt doing it brilliantly. Maybe she would discover a new niche, something she could really excel in, give herself a real sense of self worth.

At 9 o'clock, he received a text message from her to let him know it had all gone well.

> I'm going out for a few drinks with the guys once we're all finished up here—is that okay?

> Of course, sweetie—have fun!

A few drinks with her co-workers—that was great. You didn't go out for drinks after an event unless it really went well, surely. Did she want him to go along with her, though? She hadn't mentioned it specifically. Hugo hadn't met her co-workers yet. It seemed too late in the evening to start just now.

He added another line to his text message:

> I'll probably leave you to it—I need some decent sleep before tomorrow.

It wasn't actually a lie that he needed sleep. Sure, he was lazy not going out and meeting her new friends, but it was still early days. Still more important for her to bond with them than for her husband to show up having missed her big event.

> Sure, honey—we're in the Irish pub on Waverly if you change your mind!

Well, that made him feel a little more included. Nevertheless, he sent a final missive:

> Have a great time, sweetie, even if I'm not there!

Only as he was getting ready for bed did he start wondering what the chances were that Madeleine's crush might have attended her book signing event. Well, she did see him in the bookstore, he knew that much. Maybe they'd all gone on to the Irish bar where Madeleine could actively flirt with him.

Each time his thoughts ran in that direction, Hugo felt mild jealousy tugging on his heart—but each time he told himself Madeleine would be too busy that evening to flirt with her mystery man, and if it did happen, there was no way she'd take it too far.

*

Actually, when it came down to it, his body slumped as soon as he hit the pillows, so he hadn't been lying to her about his need for decent sleep. It didn't last all night, however.

At some point after midnight, he wasn't sure when, he heard the scratches of a semi-drunken Madeleine trying to get the key into the lock of their front door. Then he heard her stumble into the apartment.

He looked over at the alarm clock. Two o'clock. Impressive that she'd stayed out so late.

Hugo felt the need to feign sleep, in case it was obvious that he had been simply too lazy to go down to the Irish pub to meet her new friends

and celebrate the evening's success.

Through the open bedroom door, he could see her stumble a little as she went into the kitchen area to fetch herself a drink of water. The effects of the alcohol inside her. It warmed Hugo—she'd clearly had a good time.

"God no. Not at all."

She appeared to be speaking to somebody on her cell phone again. He could hear her voice surprisingly clearly—but then the apartment really wasn't that big. This bedroom and the living room together were probably the same size as a normal room for a normal apartment in a city in which it didn't cost the earth to live.

Her words slurred slightly, but her tone suggested to Hugo that she assumed her husband was both asleep and unlikely to wake from her conversation.

"I might have done... no, it wasn't like that," she was saying to the person on the other end of the line.

This late at night, Hugo was willing to gamble a major internal organ that she was talking to Lucy again.

He played dead as Madeleine appeared at the bedroom door, peering into the gloom to check on him. She looked so wonderfully fuckable, even if he was a little sexually frustrated.

"...Oh, you should have seen him, Luce..."

Hugo's ears pricked up at confirmation that she was talking to Lucy, and the words and tone that indicated that Madeleine was discussing things she did not want her husband to know.

"...God, he made me feel all funny inside..."

Hugo felt all funny inside to hear her say that.

Madeleine stepped back from the bedroom door, apparently satisfied her husband was asleep, that as usual he was not going to be woken until the morning.

"Don't... I have to get some sleep tonight!"

As she withdrew into the living room, Hugo found himself slipping silently out of bed, moving like a sniper to the edge of the doorway. Then, he was back out there in the little hallway, feeling vulnerable though the shadows concealed him. He had a perfect vantage point from which to watch his stunning wife as she stood in front of the living room windows, checking out the neighborhood while she spoke to her friend on the phone.

She was still glowing from her evening's triumph, and he already knew the whole thing had been a triumph from the cheery tone of her voice and the light in her eyes.

Was it his imagination, or was her hair just a little blonder than it had been for years? Touching up the highlights for the benefit of flirting with other men.

"You always did go for the tall dark strangers."

"Shut up."

Out there in the apparent privacy of the living room, Madeleine had put Lucy on speakerphone—Hugo could hear her, quietly, on the other end of the line.

"Hey it's not cheating if you're just thinking about it, right?"

Hugo felt his heart skip a beat. What was Lucy talking about?

Madeleine's pretty face crinkled as she hissed into the phone:

"Seriously, I told you not to say that—I'd never cheat on him."

Hugo caught his breath. What was his wife talking about using words like that? Suddenly, he felt his heart pulsating in his chest, he almost wondered if Madeleine might hear it.

"But you are thinking about it."

"Lucy!"

Despite her protest as she now walked further toward the windows, Hugo saw one of her hands slip delicately into the button-down opening of her white blouse, and then she appeared to be cupping one of her breasts.

Hugo held his breath.

She was quietly coaxing one of her breasts—he could see her fingers under the material of her shirt teasing her nipple. Was he going to witness another of her secret shows?

Lucy said through the phone: “Well a girl has a right to a sex life—even if she’s married. Especially if she’s married.”

“I have one,” Madeleine said, and Hugo wondered why his wife felt the need to lie to her friend. “We just hit a dry spell.”

Hugo felt the sharp, cold fingers of despair clutching at his heart from the reminder that they hadn’t actually had sex for weeks. Months, even. God, when had the last time actually been? In Boston before they’d even moved?

“And right there is why I am never getting married. So what is he like?”

“Oh God—don’t!”

“Could you see if he’s hung?”

“Lucy, Jesus! Okay, I really have to go. We’ll end up waking Hugo up.”

“You should show him what he’s been missing all night.”

“I have to go, Luce...”

“You can think of your new hottie as you’re showing him...”

“Goodbye.”

Madeleine smiled and shook her head at her best friend and Maid of Honor as she hung up.

Hugo now found himself regretting not making it to Madeleine’s little post event celebration. His chest quivered, feeling as though someone had their fingers curled around his heart and was now squeezing. What had happened? Was his sexually unsatisfied wife pursuing another man?

He breathed. Tried to remain calm. Madeleine had said clearly that she wouldn’t cheat. She’d never do that. But she’d never actually denied

thinking about it.

Seven

Hugo felt his stomach burning. The idea of Madeleine having a crush on someone kept at a safe distance was one thing, but for her to actually meet him, get to know him, flirt with him at a real life event—at which her husband had been absent—that seemed like a whole different ball game.

Or was he annoyed at himself for failing to attend an event at which Madeleine's new crush had been present? Missing out on the spectacle of her interaction with someone she actively fantasized about?

He knew Lucy was probably just toying with her friend, looking for idle but irresistible gossip that probably wasn't there. He had to ignore it. But it was hard to ignore as he watched his wife standing in front of the windows, smiling wistfully, gazing off into the distance with a mysterious glint in her eyes.

Could she see whichever college student had caught her fancy? Or was she dreaming about her boss, that tall Latino?

Slowly, almost as though it was her subconscious controlling her, he watched as Madeleine's thumbs slipped into the waistband of her smart suit skirt, and right in front of those wide open windows, she was sliding the garment down over her beautifully round behind, revealing the tiny pale fishtail of her white cotton thong panties, and the smooth flesh of her shapely rear.

She closed the blinds almost completely, just enough so that she could see out. So she wasn't actually an exhibitionist. But the way she was standing there in just her shirt and the kind of sexy little panties she hadn't worn since their dating days, she seemed to be thinking about it. Was that a fantasy, too?

In the same way that he'd never thought his wife would ever had eyes for another man, he sure as hell never thought she'd sit in a window fantasizing about showing off her naked body in public. What mysteries she'd kept from him all that time.

Perched on the window seat, in what seemed to be her regular place for this kind of thing, Madeleine hesitated a moment or two, as though deciding whether or not to proceed. Could she see anyone out there? Had anyone spotted her? Hugo could not see from where he lurked. He felt his manhood tingling between his legs. Was his wife really about to offer another little glimpse into her fantasy world?

Hugo was nearly beside himself with excitement as she leaned back against the wall. He had to keep himself calm, stop himself from overreacting to the thrilling exposure of her sexuality.

Madeleine looked over to the windows again as she began running her fingers lightly over her body, over the rise of her chest and across her bare midriff. He got the impression she was considering whether she truly was as bold as her fantasies, whether she was actually able to do this in front of a wide open window, so that anybody could see.

Her hand flowed over her stomach and then down between her legs, and she turned her head away from the window, her eyes closing as her fingers began to stroke her mound through her thin white cotton panties. Her breathing was so deep, and he could hear it perfectly across the small apartment—the silky sounds were so sexy, more beautiful than the sweetest melody.

While one hand slipped a breast out of her bra, her other hand nudged aside her panties to find contact with her bare pussy.

As she touched herself, her hips stirred, her body undulating with the rhythm of her desire. Hugo was transfixed—her movements had such innate grace, such flowing elegance.

Madeleine glanced up toward the windows again, and he saw a mischievous grin spread across her face, that devilish part of her that her

husband barely knew existed, now delighting in the possibility that someone out there could see her.

Hugo found himself wishing he could be over there across the street, even just for an evening, to see what someone in one of those apartments might see assuming the blinds were no barrier. The perspective from the true audience for his wife's display.

Hugo drew in a sudden breath as Madeleine twisted her hips, so that her pink flower was suddenly exposed to him, though hidden from the windows. There were perks to being here, rather than across the street, after all. Her fingers slid into her groove, tracing out the shape of her pussy.

What was she thinking about as she touched herself, as those sensual sighs turned to gentle moans? Her husband? Probably not. One of her co-workers? Her boss? Her crush across the street?

Hugo felt darkness inside him at the thought that she was picturing rival as she slipped two fingers inside her tight pussy. A guy built along the same lines as the tall Latin guy at the bookstore.

As he thought about it, and the pangs of jealousy snapped at his insides, a big part of him seemed to like the idea of Madeleine fantasizing about being with such a man. It was the naughty streak inside her, the wicked insatiable harlot in there, which perked up his own libido. There was something primal about Hugo's own feelings, he was sure of it. He was responding to the danger of her infidelity by becoming more sexually powerful himself—to give him more firepower to spread his genes rather than allowing her to carry those of another male.

Was Madeleine getting off on her exhibitionism, or her thoughts of infidelity?

All the questions spinning around his head almost meant he missed seeing her reach for the bag she'd left down there on the floor, then retrieve something long and lilac colored. Once again, Hugo found

himself gasping for breath as he spotted the shape of a fairly large vibrator.

Oh. My. God.

Heartbeat suddenly quickening, his pulse audible as his body fought to keep up with the adrenaline now surging around his frame, he watched as she turned back to the windows, sex toy in hand.

She glanced over towards the bedroom, and Hugo felt a sudden moment of shock, afraid she'd spotted him.

But then she simply turned away from the window, presenting her back to the glass, swinging her legs off the window seat.

Hugo had to stifle another gasp as she edged a little further forward, opening her thighs, showing him everything. It made him think that for so long in their relationship, he'd never really just looked at his wife naked before—never really appreciated her beauty. Sure, she'd probably never allowed him to just look—there had always been a pressure to get to where they were going next, to find the shortest route to orgasm.

But here she was now, balanced on the edge of the window seat, switching on the vibrator so its low buzz pierced the still air, brushing it over her breasts and trailing it around her nipples.

Oh God, he could smell her arousal. That earthy, musky, dark scent. Despite the fact she was across the room from him, it infiltrated the air, and filled his nostrils, spurring on his heart rate to ridiculous speeds. He almost lost it there and then, but he was trying desperately to be silent. Even to the point of restricting his breathing.

Another glance his way. Had she seen him sitting there in the darkness, watching her?

He had to keep his breathing under complete control as she slid her vibrator down over her mound, its humming tip gliding along her outer lips, then in along her glistening folds, sliding through her groove.

Madeleine was so exquisite, rocking her hips back and forth gently as she stirred the little humming shaft around and inside her wet pussy.

Back when they were first dating—eight years ago—Hugo remembered her allowing him to watch as she'd touched herself. The first time any girl had, it was seriously hot—God, how incredible she'd looked showing him how she made herself come. That kind of foreplay had faded from their repertoire since then.

She'd never ever shown him anything involving a vibrator, though.

Although she was already warmed up, Hugo was surprised how quickly the little thing took her from quiet, sensual sighs up to desperate, urgent cries as she circled it around her sensitive lips, touched the shaft down against her pussy, kneaded the flesh around her clit, pushed the head inside her tight hole.

No man could compete with this, he thought with a smile.

But when she slipped it inside her pussy, penetrating herself with it, was she imagining another man sliding into her, another cock squeezing into her tight slit?

She was so wet, her scent so strong in the air, it was driving him crazy—and yet Hugo felt unable to do anything but press his hand against his stiff cock—any movement could have him discovered. To see him there, Madeleine would be outraged—feeling justifiably violated, her personal privacy rights shredded.

Hugo took a deep breath, trying to push away the cold claws of guilt again—he'd stop. This would be the last time, Madeleine did not deserve to be spied on, for all her flirtatious carrying on with other men.

For now, though, he watched her pull her knees up under her chin, her little cries becoming a constant whimpering as she lodged the buzzing stick in her slippery groove, pressing its length hard into her lips so that it touched her pussy and clit, oiled by her arousal.

He saw her body tremble, her hips tense up, her movement becoming jerky, out of control as she neared a thunderous climax.

“Oh yeah, oh yeah...” she was crying, her whole frame quivering as a tumultuous conclusion rippled through her flesh.

Hugo very nearly came in his pants, without even touching himself.

Eight

He had an open invitation to the next evening event at Madeleine's bookstore, but in the days leading up to it, he saw that she was quietly making assumptions that he wasn't going to be there.

Knowing work, knowing the way something could spring up at the office any moment, he didn't raise her hopes that he would be there, either. After everything that happened after the first one, however, he saw this one as a must attend event.

Frustratingly, on the Monday Hugo found himself unable to escape from a business trip right across the country. They were supposed to make a pitch to a sudden hot prospect—Ray and Lowego would be going with him.

“And it has to be this week?”

“It'll impress them that we can drop everything and just go,” Lowego was very enthusiastic, dead certain they'd get the business this way.

“And we'd definitely get back Thursday? There's this thing I have to go to—”

“We head out on the Tuesday night, pitch Wednesday, there's a flight Thursday gets in a lunch time—you'll be back for the afternoon.”

It sounded okay to Hugo, though he was a trifle concerned about the potential for flight delays.

*

Lowego wasn't at the airport when they all met up for the morning flight to San Diego the next day. Ray was laughing about it, and Hugo was a little surprised he was taking it humorously, since this was Ray's

big pitch and Lowego was supposed to be the good cop to Ray's bad in the presentation. Davis just wasn't as good as a stand-in.

"He picked up his wife's phone by mistake this morning," Davis was explaining to Hugo, as the last to arrive at JFK, since apparently Ray was spluttering and chortling just a little too much to recount the tale.

"He had to go back for his?" Hugo asked.

"No. Was going to let it go, let her use his. Only then he got this text message on his wife's phone while he and Ray were checking in."

"Toe sucking!" Ray blurted out among peels of fresh laughter, his whole face red like he was going to burst a blood vessel any minute.

Davis seemed much more sympathetic to whatever plight Lowego now found himself in. The perpetual stand in for this little team, Davis appeared in touch with the downtrodden.

"Looked like the message was from some other guy," he said. "A couple more came through as he was trying to figure out exactly what it was, what it meant."

"Another guy who thought he was texting Lowego's wife?" Hugo asked, trying not to provoke Ray into a further barrage of giggles.

"Exactly. I guess she's not been entirely faithful. Hell of a way to find out."

"She's a dirty bird," Ray said, trying to calm himself. "He'll do well just to walk away."

"What if he still loves her?" Davis asked him, apparently trying to control a hint of anger at Ray's lack of empathy. "They are married, you know."

"Marriage is overrated. He's got a good out, now."

Hugo didn't know Lowego all that well yet, but the sense that a guy's marriage had just imploded was heavy, whoever it was. Would he really walk away from it? Could he forgive his wife? As they drifted onto the plane, found their seats, buckled up, Hugo couldn't help but try to imagine how he would feel in Lowego's place.

What if he returned from his trip early to discover her in bed with someone else?

That thought made him feel a strange mix of out-and-out horror and dizzying excitement.

Why on Earth should he feel that way?

It was like being pushed out of an airplane. The rush of the air as he plummeted toward the ground making him feel exhilaration despite the massive fear of death that gripped him.

*

Checking into an empty hotel room at the Hilton on the Bayfront made Hugo miss Madeleine intensely. It had only been a few hours—and it would be only a couple of nights away from her—but he felt such an empty hole where she should have been.

The view out of the window was pleasant enough, with the sparkling blue of the bay, the white boats in the marina and the towers of downtown San Diego just past the great expanse of exhibition center. But he didn't want to stay here, dwelling on things alone.

Hugo was only too pleased to meet up with the others after a quick change, to prepare for an evening dinner with their prospective clients. The distraction was highly welcome.

Davis and Ray seemed to have forgotten about Lowego—more important things had come to the forefront of their attentions now, as they built up to the pitch meeting the next day.

All through dinner, though, as they all tried desperately not to talk about business, to gel with their potential business partners on a personal level so that they'd all be so much more receptive to the pitch—Hugo kept finding his mind drifting off, wondering what Madeleine was up to at that moment.

Working at the bookstore again?

Or having dinner with someone?

He had to stop himself from thinking that stuff. A visit to the restroom saw him splashing cold water all over his face, telling himself that it would be just far too much coincidence for Lowego to be facing the prospect of a straying wife, only for Hugo to face exactly the same issue at the same time.

After that, he tried to focus on that thought: Madeleine doesn't need anyone else. She wouldn't do that to him, not after all the support he'd given her through the dark times. He tried to ignore that small part of him which, deep down, had begun to hope that Madeleine was considering seeing someone else, if that was what it took to guarantee her happiness and her full recovery from such debilitating depression.

And later, when he called her, and she was quite clearly—from the background noise—lounging in front of the TV watching Conan, no doubt in her sweatpants, it brought some relief to him. Her relaxed tones while she asked about the hotel, about dinner, about his hopes for the pitch meeting the next day—that also helped calm him.

That strange little part of him, though, felt mildly disappointed that he had caught her at home, doing the usual thing for a weeknight.

God, he was a mess.

*

The pitch went well, though it wasn't very inspiring work. Telling a sportswear manufacturer how they might be able to get journalists excited by a new kind of sports shoe had never been part of Hugo's career plan.

On the way back to the hotel, Hugo only wished that they could be flying back this evening, so he could be certain of attending Madeleine's event the next day. It made him feel a little guilty to be thinking he should be there to see what happened.

He did trust her. He didn't need to check up on her. He didn't need to make sure she gave in to Lucy's suggestions and went a little beyond flirting. He didn't need to be there in case he had to step in to pull his wife away from a predatory suitor.

So why did that strange, dark part of him actively want to know other men were openly attempting to seduce Madeleine? Thinking of her responding with batted eyelids and coy blushes, making faint suggestions that if they kept up, and they said just the right thing, she might be tempted to stray.

He took a hot shower to try to take his mind off things.

When he stepped out, he decided at the very least, he ought to call her. It was already late—she would be ready for sleep. If he was going to call her, it had to be now.

God, he was trembling as he picked up the phone, touched on her name on the dial. Why couldn't he just talk to her? Tell her how he felt?

The line was not good as they were finally connected. Over the crackle and fizz of the poor link-up, Hugo almost thought he could hear the low hum of people socializing.

"Hey sweetie! How did it go?" Madeleine shouting into her phone, and not merely because of the weak connection. "You guys win the contract?"

"I think so!" he said, raising his voice since he suspected she was in a bar or restaurant from the background noise.

"Can't really hear you very well, sweetie," she yelled.

"You still at the store?"

"We came out for a few drinks after work," she said. "They wanted to celebrate because head office wants to attend my event to see if the idea would work at other stores in the state!"

"That is incredible, honey—well done!"

Hugo felt the warmth of pride swarm through his system again.

"Are you gonna make it tomorrow?"

“I’m not sure, honey, I’ll try—there aren’t too many flights unfortunately, so it’ll be a tight squeeze. If there’s any kind of delays—”

“Hey, if you can’t make it, there will be others!” she said. He thought she sounded okay about him missing the event. Was it still the sense that he’d prove a distraction at the book signing, or because he would see her with other guys, particularly her crush?

“Hey... the phone... reception’s really bad—” Madeleine said, her voiced breaking up.

“Of course, honey—just wanted to hear your voice before I went to bed,” he said, adding: “Don’t you stay out too late, not the night before your big day!”

“I think we’ll be heading home soon!” she said, her voice so cheerful, she was making him tingle between the thighs again.

The way she said ‘we’ when she talked about going home sent a hot flush through Hugo’s system, his paranoia reacting to the indication she might be subtly referring to her intentions that night for warming her cold, lonely bed.

Why was he tingling all over at such a thought? At the idea of some colleague of hers being unable to keep his hands off his sexy wife, Madeleine tipsy and full of mischievous, lustful energy at the clear signs of adoration from another man.

“Okay, have a good time anyway,” he said. “And I hope everything runs smoothly tomorrow if I don’t get the chance to talk to you before.”

“Oh, it’ll be okay—I’ll see you tomorrow, whatever time you get in,” she said.

Then as Hugo was in the middle of saying: “Love you”, the phone line finally died. He was left in an uncomfortable silence, sitting there on his own on the edge of the bed in a luxurious but empty hotel room. Did he call her back only to say goodbye? Would she think him pathetic?

They’d been married five years, she knew he loved her. He didn’t need to call her back just to say it and then goodbye. She’d think he was

ridiculous.

A text came through—Madeleine.

> Sorry we got cut off! Love you! Get some good sleep, can't wait to see you tomorrow night!

It gave him a sizable sense of relief. He texted back:

> Love you too, sweetie, see you tomorrow!

His dreams that night were of Madeleine, naturally enough. Of her beauty, of her happiness, of her raw sexual power. Images of her slowly, sensually removing her clothes, displaying herself for an unseen audience across the street. He saw flashes of Lucy, half-remembered from their time at the Globe or even as far back as their wedding. Lucy giggling with Madeleine, Lucy encouraging Madeleine to cheat on her husband. Madeleine blushing at some faceless guy, nodding consent at whatever dangerous offer he was making.

Madeleine taking the hand of another man, allowing herself to be led away to some exhilarating illicit seduction.

Madeleine sighing and moaning as she was penetrated by a vibrator, which in Hugo's dream suddenly turned into a frighteningly real live erect cock.

When he awoke in the morning, Hugo found he'd had the first wet dream he could remember having since his teenage years.

Nine

After a long day spent flying, even though a good three hours was simply stolen by the time difference from West to East Coasts, Hugo felt pretty tired as they finally got into JFK.

By the time he'd gotten home and unpacked, he hardly needed to look at the clock to know he could still make Madeleine's soiree. He just felt it in his bones.

He decided, after a quick change into something smart but casual, that he would duck into the event, and perhaps try to keep a low profile. Madeleine didn't need to know he was there—he could tell her afterwards, if it felt right.

Madeleine's bookstore was down in a little street close to NYU which had a surprisingly cutesy feel, with little shops and a couple of half-decent looking bars. Bathed in the slow twilight of a summer evening, it took on a Disneyfied air that made Hugo think he was walking onto the set of a movie. This was the kind of scene to which Internet retail was putting an end, he thought as he approached the little store that had somehow resisted both the challenge of the Barnes & Noble, Books-a-Million, scourge of independent stores as well as the more recent Amazon-backed slow demise of the physical bookstore.

Shelf Indulgence—it even had a cutesy name.

The party was already spilling out onto the street as Hugo drew near. He was impressed—he was happy to admit it—he was already really impressed. The place seemed quite full, very lively.

Hugo was nervous to say the least—but, at last, he bit the bullet and headed inside. He was immediately accosted by the offer of nibbles.

“Vol au vent, sir?”

“No, thanks.”

“The readings will be getting underway shortly.”

“Thanks.”

Many of the people appeared to Hugo as though they’d stepped out of the English Literature department of the nearby university, on both sides of the faculty, from the older bespectacled professors in their frayed tweed jackets to the younger postgrads talking animatedly about the earlier works of the guest speaker of the evening, one Horatio Marks, along with a smattering of the more bookish of the student body. There were some locals, some vegetarian, hemp-shoed liberal culture aficionados and even a few professionals like Hugo, dropping by after a day at the office.

It was a merry affair, with glasses clinking as virgin cocktails were passed around and supped over improving conversation. Inside, the place was surprisingly large—he hadn’t appreciated the full extent of the place on his first visit. It expanded from a ground-level front space to a lower ground floor that ventured quite far back, split by a labyrinth of shelves and tables stuffed with books.

Hugo came through to what appeared to be the main interior space, where a wide expanse of floor had been cleared to provide seating in front of a microphone primed for artistic expression.

He spotted Madeleine almost immediately, hobnobbing with some particularly artistic-looking guys, one of whom he assumed was the draw of the evening, Horatio Marks. Madeleine did not spot him, but Hugo was not in the mood to march up to her and pronounce his arrival. There’d be a better moment—he didn’t want to spoil her networking opportunities.

A few brief scraps of conversation with a poet from Kentucky and a semi-retired management consultant from Queens made him feel a little less like a social leper as he waited for any kind of opportunity to signal his presence to Madeleine without scaring the bejesus out of her.

He waited and watched her, blown away at how well she was able to work the room.

Madeleine was dazzling among the shelves, the halogen lighting glinting off her blonde highlights, that million-dollar smile bringing light and life to the darkest of corners, engaging the quietest of customers into talking with the bigwigs who accompanied her. All male eyes seemed besotted by her.

God she looked incredible. Had she dropped a few pounds recently, or was it simply the extra confidence that made her look so delicious in that skirt. The gym she'd joined was paying off. She certainly had a healthy glow about her as she busied about the place.

Hugo wondered if any of these people happened to live across the street from their apartment—or if any of them might have caught Madeleine's eye.

Watching the artsy bigwigs fawning all over Madeleine was also too amusing for him to really want to disrupt it by stepping in with a blunt introduction.

Hugo found his way to the seating area, and managed to bag a seat in an unobtrusive location, toward the back of the room, where he could slump down and watch. When he was settled, he could watch Madeleine from the safety of the crowd—and she was magnificent.

She certainly had the event organized perfectly. It started out with a reading from the author, but then a handful of fans were invited up to read out short passages of the book that they loved.

Then a lively Q-and-A session suggested that a large contingent of the crowd were fans, well targeted by Madeleine's marketing efforts. Afterwards, there was a chance to browse the store.

Hugo managed to keep hidden from his wife extremely well while taking in the evening's proceedings, while managing to watch her from afar. She was truly great at her job—keeping the author happy, networking with her customers, maintaining control on her eager staff,

all with effortless aplomb. The folks from head office had to be impressed.

And she looked so happy, so vibrant in her conversation and in her subtle management style, really loving the chance to engage with the readers and discuss the books and the author.

“You’re here!”

He turned at the familiar voice, but at first thought it must be coincidence. No—she was really here, in the flesh.

“Lucy. What are you doing here?”

“Providing support?” she said with a wry grin. “What about you? I assumed you weren’t going to make it...”

“Oh, I’ve been here a while,” he said. “Checking it all out, you know.

Their Maid of Honor was a sharp Asian American in a smart dark blue blouse and long dark pants that were well tailored to show off her svelte figure. Was she after a little male attention as well? What happened to that Greg guy she was with, the football guy from the Herald?

“You’re not going to tell her you’re here?” she asked, and he knew she’d noticed him hanging back, leaving Madeleine to it. Watching her.

“I thought maybe I’d give her a little time to settle in, you know, without any added pressure from having a husband here.”

Lucy nodded. “You know those guys are all falling over themselves to hit on her?”

He knew Lucy was a troublemaker, a gossip queen, but her suggestion nevertheless drove a stinging jab of jealousy into the center of his chest.

“Really? It all seems very civil to me.” He feigned naiveté, but felt himself blushing all the same. God, he actually enjoyed that dangerous, helpless feeling that came with knowing that Madeleine was indulging in the admiration and enthrallment swirling around her.

“Oh trust me,” she said. “For New York literati, that is uncontrolled flirtation—bordering on propositioning.”

As they watched, Madeleine appeared gripped by the conversation of one middle-aged guy in a dark purple shirt who had his top two buttons open to display a disconcerting hint of chest hair—and she was smiling flirtatiously, one hand playing with a strand of her hair as he spoke.

“And she likes it, too, naughty wench,” Lucy said, her forced whisper drenched with something Hugo took to be awe.

“Oh, I’m sure it’s nothing,” Hugo said.

“Aren’t you going to step in? Rein it in a little?”

He shrugged. “She’s enjoying herself—that’s all I could ask for.”

“Seriously?”

As they watched, another man swung by, and it took a moment before Hugo recognized him as the Latino Madeleine had seemed particularly close to in the bookstore when he’d dropped by the other evening.

Now, there she was again flashing him a knowing glance.

Lucy said: “She likes him, whoever he is. One of the guys from the store, I guess.”

Her goading sparked another burst of heat inside Hugo’s stomach. There was certainly a connection there. Was Lucy right? Did he have to step in and show himself?

Hugo felt a touch awkward. He really did not want to play the heavy-handed husband figure, wading in to make his presence known. While Lucy attempted to rile him, he did quietly enjoy the sheer exhilaration Madeleine was clearly feeling at the center of this lively gathering of minds and culture.

And seeing these bigwigs throwing themselves at her—the others in that little group attempting to draw her attention away from Mr. Purple Shirt—warmed him up inside, somehow.

They might be hitting on her, but Hugo got to accompany her home at the end of the evening.

He saw Lucy's puzzled expression, however, and knew she was not going to be happy without some kind of explanation.

"See, for three years she's been miserable, and there's been precious little I could do about it," he said.

"It was the condition. The depression." Lucy knew full well what Madeleine had been through, though she'd never quite know how it had really been. Madeleine had always put on something of a public face, even in the bleakest of times. Only Hugo had seen the full condition.

"I took care of her as best I could, but nothing seemed to pull her out of it."

"So what're you saying? Now she's out of it, you'll let her get away with murder?"

Hugo shook his head. He did feel slightly hurt that his wife was apparently back in the mood for sexual activity, and was cheerful enough to flirt with other men, yet had not put any moves on him. But at the end of the day he had to give her space. He had to let her do as she needed to in order to get to where she needed.

How could Lucy appreciate that?

He said: "When it got really bad, you know, she couldn't even get out of bed. What can I say—I guess it all made me feel pretty miserable as well."

"Of course it did."

"I had to hide that from her... well, the guilt would've just shoved her straight back in that dark place."

Lucy just stood there and looked at him, eyes full of pity. Was he milking the history a little, to get her off his back? Perhaps. Nothing he said was a lie, though.

They waited while a brunette dressed up in a maid's uniform delivered cocktail replenishments.

“But things are better now, aren’t they?”

“Things are much better,” he nodded, even smiled again. “Can’t you see?”

“Sure I can—and so can those guys.”

He shrugged again. “Compared to Boston—I kind of enjoy seeing her all flirtatious.”

“Enjoy?”

He chuckled. “She’s not going to go off with that guy in the purple shirt, just because he’s hitting on her.”

“Normal guys—normal guys would not let their wives flirt with other men.”

“Normal guys have not been through what we’ve been through.”

“I think by the sounds of it you coped really well.”

Hugo breathed, tried to relax, tried to get the subject back round to safer territory. He said: “The thing is, Luce, when Madeleine smiles... it’s the most beautiful thing you’ve ever seen. I’ll do anything in my power to keep that happening.”

“That’s very sweet.”

“Only, over the last few years, it’s been a pretty rare occurrence.”

“Of course.”

“If it takes a little attention from other guys to bring it back—well, that’s fine. I’m sure it’s helping with her recovery.”

“So how far do you leave it? Until one of them asks her out?”

“I know you won’t understand me,” he said. “But it makes her happy—and as I’ve said, knowing that Madeleine is happy has this strange affect on me. How can I not want that to continue?”

He could see that Lucy didn’t understand him. She said: “So what happens now?”

Hugo said: “If I wasn’t here, what would she do after one of these events?”

“The bookstore guys all slink off to the Irish bar round the corner usually, from what she’s said before. I guess Maddie would be kind of obligated to join them.”

Hugo nodded. “I think she’d enjoy that. More than coming home with me instead.”

“So you’re just going to leave her to it?”

“She needs some independence, doesn’t she?”

He could see something in Lucy’s eyes, something akin to surprise and panic. She knew something, knew something about Madeleine that she wasn’t saying. She seemed to approve of Hugo’s attitude that Madeleine should be allowed to enjoy herself, particularly after such a success with the evening’s event—but there was some danger under the surface that she wasn’t talking about.

Hugo felt suddenly a little afraid, the overheard talk of cheating came back to mind. Yet he had to follow through on what he’d said—he couldn’t linger at this event now, had to allow Madeleine free reign to enjoy herself here, and then at the bar.

“You’ll keep an eye on her for me, won’t you?” he smiled, trying to act calmly.

“Uh... sure,” Lucy said.

Ten

Once Hugo had returned home, Lucy continued trying to coax him back to the bookstore via text messages, and when the party moved on to the Irish basement bar round the corner, she stepped up her effort to get him back out.

> She's getting quite friendly with this guy, whoever he is.

Hugo texted back:

> She's just having a little fun, getting a little attention. She won't take it too far.

Lucy's reply came back:

> She's progressed to the G&Ts—she gets very flirty on G&Ts. You were warned, Mister.

He smiled. Lucy was a gossiping troublemaker—perhaps she wasn't the best person to have texting him about Madeleine's activities. She had an agenda—to get him down there so she had a familiar face to hang with—and he had no doubt she was going to tease him all night with suggestive texts about his wife, just to provoke him.

He tried to settle down in front of the TV, avoiding thinking about what might or might not be happening. Lucy was spiking his appreciation for the acting talents of Zoey Deschanel, in her new TV sitcom, by sending him a continuing stream of comments designed to rile him.

> She's leaning in pretty close to him—maybe you should come down here.

Or:

> She keeps touching her hair while she's talking to him—you know that's a sign of trouble?

Or:

> She's stroking her neck. Dead. Giveaway.

Hugo couldn't help feeling a little pang of jealousy with each text that Lucy sent him, though he knew she was most likely winding him up. He had seen Madeleine with that co-worker of hers, even just briefly. Those knowing glances, that hint of affection was purely because she knew him so much better than the others in that place. It could all be misread, but Lucy's observations—if that was what they were—did lend fuel to the fire.

> You know she's interested if she keeps pushing up her boobs for him.

After a while, he started to regret not being able to see Madeleine flirting. She must look so sexy, all those peacocks prancing around her, puffing up their chests and their plumage to try to attract her interest.

It was getting late—but when Hugo headed off to bed, Madeleine still hadn't returned from the bar.

Lucy was continuing her reportage from the front line, even this late on, trying to persuade him to get down there and strong-arm Madeleine away from her friend or friends, whoever they were.

> Okay, if I were married, I would not let someone else put their hand on my spouse right there. Or anywhere, for that matter.

He sent a brief text to Madeleine saying how tired he was after his flight, adding that he hoped she was having a good time, and that she should get a cab home whenever she was ready.

Then he just collapsed—physically unable to remain awake, even if he wanted to.

*

Although he sensed that Madeleine quite liked doing her own thing with these book-signing evenings of hers—no doubt since it allowed her to indulge in this new flirtatious side of her personality with whole load

of strangers—he also felt the slight sense of awkwardness whenever she talked about them, that he had not yet officially attended one of her events.

He had assumed Lucy would eventually let slip that he had actually been to one of her evenings. Yet for some reason, Lucy never did give the game away that he'd been there.

If Lucy and Madeleine shared everything, why did that remain a secret?

As he thought about it in the days after that particular evening, he realized that if she wanted to, Lucy could have told Madeleine that Hugo knew about her flirting with other guys, and that he supported her doing it. Lucy was the only one who knew. So why was she holding back this sensitive information from her best friend?

Whatever her reasons, Lucy was keeping his secrets, leaving Hugo perfectly happy to let his wife have her independence at her book signings, to have fun with her adoring literati flocking around her.

Eventually, though, he felt obligated to officially attend one of her book signings.

“Oh, fantastic,” Madeleine had said when he told her he had a free evening for once, and he wanted to come see what she was doing with these events of hers.

He caught the note of anxiety in her eyes from his acceptance of an invitation she had not entirely expected him to accept.

“Lucy told me how well it went when she was there,” he said.

“She did?”

“Sure. So I figured I need to see it for myself.”

He even took the afternoon off from work, to ensure absolutely nothing could come up to pull him away.

When he got there, instead of hanging back and lurking in the shadows, he made himself known to his wife immediately. She was all

smiles, expressing her delight that he had made it after all, that nothing had cropped up at work at the last moment.

Was there a touch of disappointment in her features, that he had come after all? That crushed his spirits a little, if only because he didn't like to disappoint her.

"Well, it's great you're here, sweetie," she said, her eyes darting this way and that, the distraction of an event she was responsible for throwing.

"Just forget I'm here, honey," he said, stroking her upper arm in an attempt to be reassuring.

"I'm going to have to, I'm afraid. These literature types are like herding cats—"

"Of course, of course. Hey—I'll be okay. Glass of Champagne or two..."

She gave him a half-smile, as though she wasn't really listening to him, and from his tone thought he'd probably cracked a mild joke about something despite not really being able to hear him.

Oh, he didn't mind. She had other things to think about.

"Go ahead, honey," he said, ushering her away, her final smile of genuine gratitude that he understood she couldn't spend the evening with him.

Madeleine weaved through the crowd back toward her author, who she'd left only in order to briefly connect with her husband. Without her, the guy was awkwardly talking to the man from the Times, and clearly not making any kind of impression.

Hugo felt a little bad for the author. Madeleine joined their little circle, and immediately began trying to help him out in engaging with the journalist—but it wasn't the usual Madeleine from these book signing events. She seemed somehow quieter, less enthused, flashing the occasional glance over toward her husband, as though needing to check

that he was all right—or even that he was all right that this was what she was spending her life doing these days.

She wasn't the same flirtatious young woman charming anyone who got near, inspiring the author and lulling the journalist or anyone else nearby into a state of rapture about the writing being showcased.

Hugo's presence was spoiling it for everyone.

He noticed that when Madeleine's co-workers went near her, she often seemed to turn her back—subtly, but consistently—or find some excuse to walk away, sometimes even leaving them looking visibly disappointed.

No flirting, then, not tonight.

After awhile, Hugo had to admit he was a little bored. There was no Lucy to liven up his evening, either, although her move down from Boston was imminent. He got to talk about Joyce with some fatuous type from the university, and about what Philip Roth was or was not up to these days, with some grindingly vacuous PhD from Columbia.

Everything seemed to go well enough, the audience was happy enough from what he saw. But Madeleine's performance was definitely more cautious than usual that evening. Hugo stuck around until the end, but by then he had made his mind up that he was not being a good influence on her when she was working.

When he was around, she was quieter, less confident, less showy. She wasn't even wearing the usual skirt, but a smart conservative trouser suit, her make-up more subtle, like the Madeleine of old.

Afterwards, people were still congratulating her and thanking her before they ventured out into the night air, and Madeleine put a brave face on it, accepting her praise with grace, while advising anyone and everyone to make sure they noted the date of the next event in their diaries.

Then, when Hugo was waiting patiently for his wife to finish up, he saw one of her co-workers, the handsome Latino, approach her with no

intention of being ignored.

He gave her a peck on the cheek, which would have seemed to Hugo merely a friendly gesture, except that halfway through it, Madeleine gently but firmly urged him back, as though she was worried what her husband might think.

It was that particular intimation of hers that made Hugo suddenly suspicious.

“You okay?” her colleague asked her. “You’ve been kinda down today, huh.”

She shrugged, said quietly: “I’m just a little tired.”

Then she was glancing at her husband. For a fraction of a second Hugo caught the worry on her face as she wondered if he had seen anything. He pretended he’d been looking somewhere else, he hadn’t seen a thing. She seemed relieved at that.

“I’m glad you could make it,” she said, and he stepped close to her in case she wanted a hug. She surprised him by stepping away.

Was she embarrassed about him?

Not embarrassed, he suspected—perhaps just keeping her worlds separate. She didn’t want her co-workers to know he was her husband, or maybe even that she was married at all. Surely they must know that.

“You going to that bar again afterwards?” he asked her.

“I’m not sure if I have the energy tonight.”

“Sure?”

But she said only: “Take me home.”

Later, Hugo lay in bed and felt bad about torpedoing his wife’s special evening. He’d have to make his excuses for future events.

If he was honest, he did feel slightly put out that his presence had put a dampener on the whole thing. Oh, maybe she’d had a summer cold coming on, or she was at a certain point in her monthly cycle. Maybe she’d simply had a difficult author that night, and the inspiration hadn’t

flown quite as well as normal. Maybe she had simply had a bad day. It was a coincidence if she had.

A couple of days later—perhaps even only a day later—and the funk, whatever it had been, seemed to fade. Hugo felt huge relief. He'd been afraid her bad day might see her slip into a bad week, and then a bad month, and then her condition might manifest itself once again for the long-term.

As it turned out, he could afford to be more confident in her recovery than that. Saturday came, and in the morning Madeleine was once again dressing for work in another short, short skirt. Thinking him asleep as she readied herself for a weekend shift, she put on a blouse that showed a good amount of her cleavage, and the kind of lipstick that made men melt.

Hugo felt relief, and a stirring down below at the thought she should be dressing like that for the guys down at the bookstore.

She didn't dress that way for her husband, that was for sure.

Eleven

When it came time for her next bookstore event, Hugo passed on his apologies, but did not attend. He told Madeleine a couple of days ahead of time that he had an upcoming product launch, and the required press attention was going to keep him at the office late that night.

As the evening approached, and there was nothing at work that could keep him at the office particularly late, his plan was to visit the movie theater instead.

Madeleine didn't question him, didn't cast any suspicion that he might be telling her a little white lie. He could tell she was quietly relieved he wouldn't be there.

Lucy, on the other hand, was being press-ganged into attending the event while she was down in New York again, preparing for her relocation. So she wasn't happy that Hugo was not going to be there.

That evening, as Hugo headed to check out the latest Woody Allen picture at the Regal off Union Square, he received a flurry of text messages from Lucy demanding to know why he wasn't there—particularly when he knew how flirtatious his wife got at those book signings.

Her fresh attempts to either entice or threaten him into changing his plans, to come by the book signing instead, failed on every level. When she tried to give him guilt because he wasn't there to see his wife's event, he merely said he'd been to the last one and he'd been a distraction for Madeleine. When she said he needed to come down there and stop his wife fluttering her eyelids at other men, he said simply that he trusted her.

Lucy's attempts to make him jealous merely turned him on.

>You do know how good looking the guys at her bookstore are? Not to mention all these authors hanging around her.

He liked to think of Madeleine having her pick of a swarm of attractive suitors. How excited she must feel.

> She loves it. If I were you, I'd want to be here, just in case she gets drunk again.

He wasn't going to spoil it for Madeleine, though. This was her big night—she didn't want her husband taking her attention off things.

Once again at the end of the evening, he found himself heading home alone, slipping into the cool sheets, warmed by the feeling that Madeleine must be having fun this time—that had to be the priority.

*

When he woke in the middle of the night, he saw that she was lying there beside him, like usual other than the faint whiff of alcohol that lingered about her, and the fact her face had retained smeared traces of her makeup.

He felt a mild sense of relief that she was there at all, which surprised him—had there really been a danger that she wouldn't come home that night, or any night after one of her events?

What most surprised him was the small part of him that appeared disappointed she was back lying beside him, rather than embarking on an adventure in a strange bed.

Was there something wrong with him?

Madeleine looked so beautiful, so peaceful lying there. Even with her mascara smudged and her lipstick smeared, and her hair like a nest of golden vipers.

God, they used to be able to talk about anything and everything. Still could, mostly. She was his best friend, he'd never been closer to any

other human being. So why couldn't he talk to her about anything vaguely intimate any more?

He wanted to confess to her how obsessed he had become by watching her, how incredible she looked now that her self confidence had returned. And he did want to talk about that strange, dark little urge he had to see her enjoy the attentions of other men. But if he couldn't even talk to her about why they never made love any more, how could he possibly open up about that?

Hugo sighed and rolled over. The alarm clock on the bedside table read 5am. He wasn't remotely sleepy.

He picked up his phone, only to find a string of texts waiting for him, along with a missed call from Lucy.

Hugo felt his stomach lurch. What had happened that had made her want to call him, of all things?

One text from Madeleine:

> Okay sweetie—you have a great sleep, you deserve it! Everything going great here—think the guys from head office really love what we've done! I'll try not to wake you when I get in :-) xx

The warmth of reassurance filled his chest—well, whatever else happened that night, at least Madeleine seemed happy. The folks from the Corporation must have had a good time since she was so on fire.

Next, he flicked to Lucy's string of messages.

> You know, if I were you, I would not feel comfortable with my wife working with these guys every day.

> She does look happy though.

> Are you asleep now, or ignoring me?

> I'll take that as you being asleep for the sake of our friendship.

> Okay, seriously, you might want to get down here.

> She had way too much to drink.

> I just want to put it on record: I am not responsible for what she is doing.

> I tried to intervene, but now she's gone, so what am I supposed to do?

Hugo breathed slowly, deeply, in and out. Did those final few texts suggest that something had happened? Lucy hadn't exactly gone into any details—but the fact she'd tried to call him made him start to fear the worst.

It was like the way the camera cuts away in a horror movie, leaving it to the imagination to come up with whatever really awful thing that must be happening.

As he thought about it, and felt that injection of dark, jealous acid in his stomach, Hugo also had the strangest feeling of contentment that Madeleine might have done something a little naughty. It made his stomach tie itself in knots, but his manhood was thickening between his thighs, and his loins were tingling as though he were in some shady strip club.

It was a powerful thrill that his wife was being sexy and flirtatious, and even the hint that she might turn out to be promiscuous as well some day.

Had Madeleine really left the bar with some guy?

Hugo now stared at his pretty wife's smeared lipstick, and felt himself unbelievably turned on.

Maybe he needed therapy himself.

*

It was Friday, so he had little time in the morning to wait and see if Madeleine would wake and want to talk about what might or might not have happened the previous night.

Hugo had to be in the shower, then dressed and gone before she even stirred. He felt nervous as he left her sleeping there, creeping

through the apartment to slip out of the front door, but he couldn't stay to question her.

Mid morning, he sent her a text message that was subtly inquisitive.

> Hey honey, hope you're not feeling too hung over today—you were out late, must have been a fun crowd at your event!

He so badly wanted to know what had gone on, what might have prompted Lucy to send such dramatic text messages. Yet he didn't want Madeleine to start feeling pressure from him being on her case.

And that dark, rebellious part of him deep inside wanted to avoid scaring her off from her little adulterous dalliance, if that was what had happened. God, he was messed up.

All day, he tried calling Lucy. From different phones, too, in case she was purposefully blocking him. He sent her a couple of texts asking what really happened the previous night, though he didn't want to give Lucy the impression he was on the war path.

If Lucy suggested to Madeleine that he was angry with her, things could go south very quickly.

In the end, he had to be patient. Hugo found himself sitting on the toilet mid-afternoon, taking deep breaths, trying to use reason to quell the turbulence in his chest.

He tried to look at the situation as a win-win. Maybe nothing had happened: some guy had escorted her out of the establishment and helped find her a cab to take her home. No damage. Lucy had simply gained the wrong impression about her walking out with her male friend. But if something had happened—Madeleine succumbing to temptation, finding a shady corner to make out with some other guy—well, that was kind of hot.

It wasn't as though Madeleine would ever leave her husband, just for some little thing she had about a co-worker.

It wasn't until 4 pm that he received an apologetic text back from Madeleine, and that was short on the detail he had been hoping for:

> Sorry sweetie! Had my phone on silent. Great night last night, drank way more than I meant. Think it went well, though.

It seemed perfectly innocent—maybe Lucy had been merely winding him up with her texts again, knowing he had gone to sleep. Maddie had had too much to drink, so maybe some gallant chap had put her in a taxi to keep her out of trouble.

The commute home was only mildly anxious, but then when he returned to the apartment, the sight of a smiling Madeleine seemed to put him instantly at ease.

"I am never drinking that much again," she said, as they ate burritos in front of the latest *Game of Thrones* episode on TV.

"I got a text from Lucy warning me you'd had a few," Hugo said. "You got home okay, though?"

"Someone found me a cab thankfully. No way I could have walked. I really have to watch myself in future."

"It's hard to monitor how much Champagne you have when people keep topping up your glass, huh?"

"I was too focused on the event to worry about it—I should just avoid drinking until we get to the bar."

Hugo felt deflated by the innocence of her explanations, but then what did he really expect?

They were quickly off the subject of the previous night, but the rest of the evening, Hugo did catch his wife giving him a few curious little glances, as though there was something on her mind that she wanted to talk about, but couldn't.

A few times, he popped questions to her about the book signing, about how good the author had been, about the guys from head office attending—all designed to offer her a way in to tell him if something important had happened that night. She didn't take the bait.

That evening, Madeleine kept steering the conversation away from herself, back to something safe—her husband’s job, what they should do at the weekend, exactly who was hacking who to pieces on *Game of Thrones*.

She didn’t seem entirely comfortable talking about the evening, especially what had gone on in the Irish pub.

*

A few days passed, and the subject of that particular evening evaporated completely. Hugo let it go—maybe he would never find out. He did notice a slight change in Madeleine, however, which seemed to reinforce the idea in him that something had gone on.

Firstly, she seemed a little less bubbly about everything she did. Secondly, she didn’t seem to talk about the bookstore quite so much—if at all, in fact.

The third thing that put him on edge was that over the next few days, Madeleine seemed to pay more attention to him than she ever had since they’d come to New York. It was as though she’d suddenly noticed him, realized she’d been taking him a little for granted recently, and now she felt she needed to make it up to him.

She kept looking at him, kept smiling at him but with her mouth and not really her eyes. She tried too hard to show she was interested in his life, in his job.

When she asked him about his colleagues, and the conversation turned to Lowego’s marital difficulties, at one point he thought he saw Madeleine wince. It provoked a jolt of fear in him, that the idea of marital infidelity would cause such a reaction in his wife.

But how could he reassure her, that nothing could have happened to make him stop loving her, that she didn’t need to worry about him?

He wanted to talk, but when it came to it, his lips were sealed by some unseen force.

The outcome of Madeleine's re-discovery that she had a husband was that she decided it was time to organize the anniversary celebration they had missed because of one of her book signing events.

"I can't believe I didn't see it coming—and it's our five-year anniversary, too," she said.

"We don't have to do anything too outlandish, though, do we?" Hugo felt too tired most of the time to face any kind of party.

"Of course not—I was thinking a quiet dinner, just the two of us."

"Sounds perfect."

And it really did sound perfect to Hugo—perfect as an opportunity to force himself to open up to her. A quiet dinner, just the two of them, no distractions. A little wine for courage, and he might at least state something of what was on his mind. It might prove difficult, but he knew he had to try. He desperately wanted to rekindle their passion, he missed her intimate embrace, the way she looked after they made love. The satisfaction in her that he could instill.

Maybe he needed to be honest with her about this new darkness inside him, the strange obsession he had about her sexual renaissance. His burgeoning, dark fantasy about his wife sleeping with another man.

Twelve

Madeleine waited until the dessert was out of the way before telling Hugo the reason for her recent melancholy, as though worried it might spoil their food.

For his part, Hugo had spent the entire evening trying to build up the courage to express his feelings about everything—about her recovery, her transformation, his startling new fantasy, and what was or was not going on between them.

As dessert came and went, and their conversation still dwelled in small talk and trivial matters, Hugo began to worry that he was going to miss this opportunity to open up.

He'd been practicing different lines of questioning in his head all night, slurping wine in the hope that it would give him the boldness he needed. His difficulty wasn't that he was afraid of making a fool of himself—the bigger fear was upsetting Madeleine, angering her. And on this night they were supposed to be celebrating their relationship.

Then the waiter left them alone with their coffee, and Madeleine came round and gave her husband a shock.

“I kissed someone.”

There was no real lead up to it, no introduction, no preamble, no small talk. No softening the blow.

She just blurted it out.

“I kissed a guy.”

Hugo felt stunned, quite stunned.

Madeleine looked at him as though he were a ghost, frozen in fear at what he might do in response to her revelation. Hugo felt his stomach lurch quite dramatically, and he very nearly lost his evening's meal.

Oh Jesus.

For a moment he didn't know quite what to think, let alone what to say. He focused on breathing—in, out, calmly, slowly. They sat there with the gentle tinkle of the jazz piano over by the bar to give them some sense of continuity to their evening.

It was clear Madeleine needed to assuage her soul with a full confession, to end all guilt one way or the other, resolve the huge Sword of Damocles that had been hanging over her. But she'd never worked out any kind of damage limitation strategy. That was more Hugo's skill set, now he was in public relations.

"Oh God, Hugo, I'm so sorry..." her voice quiet, small, plainly terrified. "I was drunk, it really didn't mean anything..."

Yet as the initial shock melted, and his conscious mind returned, he found that what he was feeling most of all was relief. She wasn't depressed again, she hadn't lost that gloriously sexy side of herself again—she had been gripped by that tyrant of mental malaise, guilt.

It must have been at that last book-signing event that something had happened. When Lucy had tried to call him. When Madeleine had suddenly cooled.

"It was only a kiss," she said, hastily scratching for whatever mitigating factors sprang to mind.

He just looked at her.

"It really didn't last longer than a moment."

Underneath the make-up she'd put on in honor of their five-year celebration, her skin really was so pale. It almost made her look like a goth or an emo, albeit with cute blonde hair rather than depressing jet black. Her hands were pale, too, particularly her knuckles as she clung to the white tablecloth.

It was the slight quiver in her bottom lip that told him how frightened she was.

He didn't like to see her frightened. He liked to see her smile, laugh, moan in unbridled joy.

“I never meant...” Her words trailed off, as though she’d lost phone reception, except that this was a conversation in the flesh.

Madeleine was really shaking. It wasn’t cold in there at all, even if she was wearing a tiny little dress that barely covered anything. Did she imagine she’d lose him?

“Who was it?” Hugo asked.

“Someone from work. I’ll hand in my resignation,” she said. “I’ll find something else. Anything you want.”

It was frightening for him, too. Terrifying.

But underneath the surface, it made him tingle all over that this had happened. Madeleine had kissed someone. Her flirting had gone too far. How could that feel like a good thing?

Hugo wanted coffee, he wanted the check, he wanted green lights all the way home. He suddenly didn’t want to have to make life-changing decisions. If he reassured her that kissing other men was okay, she might get completely the wrong idea.

He just didn’t know what to say. He hadn’t really planned any of this, hadn’t expected any of this. His silence seemed to make Madeleine more anxious, though he didn’t want her to feel that way, his brain had frozen.

Eventually, he said: “You love that job.”

A small nod, playing down the importance of just how much her new job meant to her.

Then, his curiosity seemed to take over. He said quietly: “What happened?”

“We were in the bar afterwards. I guess everyone had quite a bit to drink. We were all really happy it’d all been such a success—the guys from head office were really pleased, and when I suggested we should go one step further and maybe work to start publishing new authors... I guess it was a surprise they wanted to run with that idea, too.”

“It was someone from head office?” Hugo found his tongue. Dry, sticking to the sides of his mouth.

“No. From the store. Fabian. He was the one who said the store should take up my ideas, encouraged me to talk to the head office guys about my small press idea...”

“He’s supported you, he’s a nice guy. You like him.”

She nodded.

“I just forgot myself,” she said. “Just for a moment.”

“You liked it?”

Madeleine did not answer that one.

“I’ll quit. I’ll find something else.” The corners of her mouth were squeezed downwards almost unnaturally far. She glanced sharp left, towards the windows and the awesome view down 5th Avenue that had so taken them both earlier in the meal, but now seemed ordinary, trivial, unimportant.

Then he saw tears coming.

He felt the sudden need to reassure her, to somehow encourage her without making her think he didn’t care. He said: “Don’t be silly, you don’t have to give up your job for a little thing like that.”

She nodded, sucked in a deep breath that was very nearly a sob.

“It meant nothing,” she said, resorting to semi-remembered lines from movies to keep from bogging down in her mind-numbing terror. “Really. It was just... you know, a few too many drinks.”

Hugo nodded slowly, sticking to his strategy of slowing everything down to give himself time to think. A politicians’ tactic.

He said, almost callously: “But you enjoyed it.”

He didn’t really mean to push it. It just seemed fascinating to him. He saw her flinch when he asked her that. Such simple little words that could cause such emotion: heated jealousy in him, ice-cold fear in her.

“I was... it was just...”

She sighed, and a lonely tear made a break for it down her cheek.

Hugo said: “And this guy from the store, this was the first time he’s ever shown interest in you?”

Madeleine shrugged, her lip quivered. She could no longer bring herself to look him in the eyes. Her voice was flat, drained of life as she answered him: “He’s never gone that far before, if that’s what you mean.”

“But you’ve enjoyed flirting with him a little, the last few months.”

Another shrug. Another tear coursing down her pale cheek.

He said: “This whole thing at work... Is this what’s made you feel so much better these days?”

She looked up, eyes suddenly sharp through the quiet tears. “Is that what you think?”

“There’s been quite a change in you, honey, since we came to New York. You have to admit.”

A little scowl at that. “I’ve been on a new treatment since we got here,” she said. “A new doctor. I’m not feeling better simply because a few guys’ve been hitting on me.”

“A few guys?” Hugo couldn’t hold back a little half-grin, and Madeleine now flushed. She looked so cute when she blushed. How could he possibly resist, whatever she’d done?

“All the guys are like that at the store. It’s not serious.”

“But then you kissed one of them.”

“I told you; I’ll quit. It won’t happen again.” Her words spiky, as though she thought he was going too far rubbing her face in it.

“No—don’t quit.” She looked up at him again, her left eyebrow raised. He said: “I like that you have fun with other people. What’s the harm in a little flirting?”

“I don’t get it. What are you saying?”

“I’m saying,” he said, his heart pounding in his chest now, his body reacting to the unnatural things he was thinking. “I’m saying, if this is what gets you leaping out of bed in the morning, it’s what brings this

confident, smiling, beautiful woman home to me again in the evening, maybe I don't want it to stop."

"Hugo, you're confusing me."

There was that sexy little crinkle between her perfectly plucked eyebrows, like she was quietly horrified at just how insane he was, which made him just want to hold her and run his fingers through her hair and kiss her until her face broke out into another one of her glorious smiles.

He said: "It was only a kiss, Madeleine."

The waiter arrived, asked if they wanted more coffee, or an after dinner liqueur. Hugo quietly ordered a single malt for himself, Baileys for Madeleine.

"So wait, you're not actually angry?" she said when they were alone again, her tone suggesting she didn't quite believe him, perhaps that she thought he was trying to trap her.

He said: "We're not dating any more, Madeleine. It's our fifth wedding anniversary. I don't think a drunken smooch with some other guy means you don't love me any more."

"Of course it doesn't."

"So, then." Hugo saw the waiter approaching with the drinks, and just in time added: "I guess if you want my honest opinion, I think it's kind of hot that guys have been showing you a little attention recently."

God, where did that come from? It was one of the lines he'd practiced earlier inside his head, but never really thought he'd be bold enough to use. The evening's wine had leant him a little courage.

"You think it's hot?" shock, now, materialized in Madeleine's face.

The waiter was slow in placing the glasses in front of them, in asking them if there was anything else they wanted. Hugo looked across the table and saw confusion in his wife's face after his unexpected response to her transgression.

Then, at last, the waiter withdrew to fetch their check.

“So let me get this straight,” Madeleine said. “You don’t want me to quit my job.”

“Of course not.”

“Even though Fabian will still be there, working with me, every day.”

A shrug, the alcohol keeping him casual. He swirled the scotch in his glass, checking out the color against the candle flame. “I don’t think you should feel bad if you’re at work, and there’s guys there that find you attractive,” he said. “And if there’s a little flirting going on, what’s the problem? It makes you feel good.”

“You’re not angry? You’re not even a little jealous?” Madeleine was beginning to sound a touch angry, disappointed by his reaction. As though she’d been preparing herself for a fight, learning her lines and practicing her moves, and he’d spoiled all her efforts by his shock decision to instantly forgive her.

“You want me to be?”

“No,” she said meekly.

“I am a little jealous, if you must know,” he said, and saw a flicker of satisfaction pass across his wife’s pretty face. Had she been hoping for that? To validate her?

“Actually, makes me feel as though I’ve been punched in the stomach by Tyson.”

“Oh, sweetie...”

He said: “The thing is... well, truth is I get a real kick out of you being happy.”

“How d’you mean?”

“All this attention you’ve been getting from other guys—whether or not your treatment’s changed, or you’ve been seeing a new therapist—it has definitely given you more confidence, has made you happier.”

“I guess...”

“So, then. I guess I’m saying that I like the change in you.”

“You’re a strange one, Hugo Finnell,” she said, but her frown lightened a little, as though she were beginning to believe him, beginning to decide he wasn’t trying to trap her. “I’m not sure I entirely understand what you’re saying.”

“Maddie, you drive me crazy, you know that?”

“Crazy?”

“You’ve been miserable for three years, maybe more. I feel like I did the best I could to support you through it, but nothing I did brought you out of it.”

“You did everything possible,” she insisted, a tear trickling down her cheek.

“If your new job, your new friends can help you where I’ve failed, then that has to be a good thing.”

“It’s not just the new job,” she said. “It’s everything—our new home, this new city. It’s a fresh start.”

“You deserve it, Madeleine. You deserve some attention.”

She flashed him a quizzical look, then sniffed up a tear, attempting a smile. “Who are you, and what have you done with the man who pulled me away from the best man at our wedding because you thought he was staring at my chest?”

“He *was* staring at your chest.” Hugo smiled in. “You were flashing him at the time.”

“That was good Champagne we had,” she giggled, and Hugo felt a warm tingling sensation spread through his loins.

God, the effect she had on him when she laughed—when she smiled, even. It was like some kind of drug, buzzing through his whole system. And he knew he was hooked, he was a bona fide addict.

Perhaps that addiction was distorting his sensibilities regarding her flirting with other men.

“We’ve been in a dark place for most of our marriage, Madeleine,” he said, serious now. Seeing the light drain out of her face as he recalled

the way it had been. “Now that we’ve emerged... I guess I’m a little dazzled by the brightness.”

Madeleine just looked at him for a long moment, and as her dark eyes flickered over his face, he saw in them genuine concern for the toll her condition had taken on him—something that was often forgotten while she’d been deep in her despair for so long.

“My therapist says there’ll be an adjustment period for both of us,” she said, surprising him to mention her therapist, something she never did, having taken years to even accept that she ought to see one, that it didn’t mean she was weak. “We just need to find our balance again.”

He nodded.

“You’re looking pretty incredible tonight, honey,” he said, and adored the way she blushed in response.

“It is a special occasion.”

“You haven’t dressed up for me for a while.”

“I didn’t really think of it until recently,” she said.

“You’ve been dressing differently at work,” he said, and he saw her face return to defensive mode. “You never used to wear skirts.”

“It’s warmer down here.” Her eyes didn’t seem to quite believe her tongue.

But he chuckled, said: “It’s not much different from Boston. And it’s not just that they’re skirts, huh? Some of them are like belts.” A wet smile, trying to inject a little humor to show her he wasn’t angry.

She was a little taken aback that he’d noticed her skirts, it seemed.

“It makes me feel... better,” she said, treading carefully as she tried to explain. “I don’t know—I never liked the way I looked before. I guess the guys at work... made me think differently. They can’t stop staring.”

“You look amazing, you always did. Women think men are only interested in stick thin models.”

“Have you ever—would you ever have said something to me about looking less than perfect?”

“Of course not, I’m your husband.”

“Exactly. And I love you for it, but you’re hardly impartial.”

“And now you’ve had a few nice comments at work...”

She glanced away from his eyes, suddenly shy. “It has given me more confidence, I guess...”

Hugo nodded. “I approve,” he said.

“And how do you know how I dress at work?” she fired back at him now. “You’re out of the door before me in the morning, and you don’t get home until long after me unless it’s the late shift, and I always wear normal stuff on the late shift.”

He smiled. “We do share the same laundry basket, Hon,” he said. “I assume you don’t leave your skimpy little skirts and tiny little tops in there just to taunt me.”

She flushed, deeply red.

“And some of the things you must wear to the gym...”

A gasp at that.

The tuxedo-clad waiter brought the check, and it was plain he could sense a real heart-to-heart was going on at their table. Could people hear their conversation? Hugo handed him a bank card and the waiter scuttled away as quickly as his little legs could carry him.

“It’s not about.... wanting someone else,” Madeleine said, breaking the silence the waiter had left behind at their table. “You do know that, don’t you? It’s never been about that.”

The scotch burned the back of his throat.

He breathed, savoring the fumes from the glass, enjoying the deep orangey, tobacco-like finish of the whisky.

“What is it about?” he asked, quietly.

“I don’t know...” she said, but the glint in her eye suggested she had at least an inkling. Now it was his turn to raise an eyebrow. She glanced in his eyes, then down at her glass of untouched Baileys.

Now she sipped the creamy liqueur.

He watched her, not giving her an easy way out of the explanation he craved. She did look incredible in a little charcoal-gray sequined dress, which suggested she was wearing no underwear underneath whatsoever. It was no hardship for him to simply sit there and gaze upon her, his eyes running down from her sharp, almost feline face, taking in her elegant neck, the clear skin of her chest and mouthwatering roundness of her cleavage.

“It’s not that I want other men,” she said, shooting him a direct look straight in the eyes. Feigning boldness, even if the slight shake of her hands gripping the tumbler gave her game away. “It’s just... it just feels good that they notice me.”

“Of course,” he said, his flat tone giving the impression he hadn’t decided yet whether to take offense.

She glanced around the near-empty establishment, double checking their privacy levels. “The guys at work are so chilled out—they know it’s not serious. They tease me, so it’s kind of expected that I’ll tease them a little.”

“And you like being a tease,” Hugo said, loving the gentle pinkness blooming in her cheeks again.

Hands on her hips, she arched her back, showing off her figure to the fullest effect considering she remained seated. She said: “I like the way they react to me, the way they look at me when they think I’m not looking. I don’t sit around hoping one of them will ask me out. I just enjoy... winding them up. Driving them crazy.”

“I’ll bet you drive them crazy,” he said, swirling his scotch, watching the golden glint from 14 years matured in oak barrels.

“I’m sorry,” she said in barely more than a whisper.

Hugo shook his head. “No,” he said, leaning forward, eyes blazing as he added quietly: “I like that you drive them crazy.”

“You like it?”

There was that crinkle in her brow again, like she thought he was nuts. She probably did.

“Does it turn you on, when they look at you?” he said in a low voice, fire continuing to flicker in his eyes. “I’ll bet it does. When they see your thighs. Look down your top. Must like those lacy bras you’ve started wearing.”

He saw her fidget, adjust her posture, squeeze her thighs together as though she was having a hard time suppressing arousal.

Beautifully shocked, she said: “Are you trying to drive me crazy now?”

He gave her a devilish grin. “I bet you got a real rush out of it at work, huh? No wonder you’ve been so on edge at night after you get home.”

“Wait, what—?”

But the waiter was there again, taking the card sitting on the check. Madeleine held her tongue, though she had questions all stacked up and ready to land.

“Bar’s open until midnight,” the waiter said to them, cocking his head towards the smart-looking but largely empty granite-topped counter running along the far wall. Subtly lit, comfortably laid out with leather-topped bar stools.

“Thanks,” Hugo said. “Sounds good.”

He rose to his feet, and gestured for Madeleine to follow suit. “Shall we?” he asked her.

She looked uncertain, turning to assess their surroundings, concerned their privacy would be somehow compromised by the change of scene. But with his outstretched hand sitting there, not budging, she relented, placed her delicate hand in his, hauled herself up.

“What do you mean I’m on edge after I get home?” she whispered as he kissed her on the cheek, breathing in the subtle floral top notes and cherry-vanilla baseline of her signature fragrance.

“I may have seen... a little more than I was supposed to,” he said, his tone becoming apologetic. The shoe on the other foot now, time for his own confession. The alcohol was making it easier for him to say what was on his mind, but Hugo suddenly worried that it would spoil things, make her angry. But this had to come out sooner or later.

“I don’t under—”

“What you do sometimes when you think I’m asleep?”

She caught her breath, shot him a sharp, startled look, realizing what he was alluding to—but now she couldn’t respond, couldn’t say anything, because he was leading her through the tables to the bar.

“Here okay?” he asked her, drawing out a barstool for her.

“Sure,” she said, feeling her throat running dry. Lifting the liqueur she’d failed to finish at the table, using the sharp but smooth, faintly chocolatey Irish cream almost as a mouthwash.

The barman topped up Hugo’s single malt, and Madeleine found to her surprise that her own glass was also now empty. How much had she had to drink that evening? Was that risking an argument? A drunken fight?

Madeleine clearly didn’t know what to say after his little revelation.

Hugo tried to explain. “I know I shouldn’t have done it. I... it caught me by surprise to start with. I guess after everything that’s happened to us... well, I wasn’t expecting you to be so... well, sexual.”

“Sexual?” Madeleine raised an eyebrow.

He said: “I guess with everything that happened, we just got used to not being physical together. Kiss on the cheek, quiet hug, maybe the occasional complement on the current outfit. I see you’re not wearing makeup, you don’t put perfume on, you cover up in baggy sweatpants—I assume you’re still off sex, you know, from before. I don’t want to force the issue, I don’t want to spoil your recovery.”

“Oh, sweetie, it’s not...”

“Only, there you are after dark, quietly finding your own little place on the window seat for a little private time.”

Madeleine looked at him, her dark eyes flickering around his face, examining every detail, assessing every nuance of his expression for clues about whether he was mad at her.

He sighed, and it seemed to defuse her fear a little. He said: “I guess it just surprised me a little, caught me off guard. I didn’t know how to react, so I just froze. Then I saw you, and I couldn’t stop watching. I didn’t want you to stop.”

She was silent still, gazing at him. Only now he was worried she was going to be angry at him.

Then she said coolly: “So you like watching, huh?”

With a somewhat sheepish smile, he said: “You were so beautiful, honey, I couldn’t help myself.”

“You were asleep,” she insisted, in mild protest. “You were snoring.”

He shrugged. “I guess you thought so.”

She flushed again, deeper than ever, startlingly, scarlet spreading down to her chest. So sexy. But beyond the blush, there was a glimmer of something there... She liked it that he was watching.

“I’m sorry,” she said quietly.

“Sorry?”

“For going it alone.”

He shrugged. “You deserve a good sex life,” he said.

“I have a good sex life.”

“Not with me you don’t.”

“Don’t be ridiculous. We’re just not ready yet.”

“I’m serious. It shouldn’t be this way—you need release. It’s only human.”

He felt suddenly afraid the evening was going to turn into an ugly argument. But things needed to be said. If only he could figure out how.

“It’s only occasionally,” she insisted with another small white lie.
“You know... when things build up.”

Hugo smiled, “I don’t have a problem with it. I love that you do it.”

“You do?”

“Of course,” he said. “Why do you think I like watching you?”

Madeleine’s dark eyes blazed like never before. “You’re such a bad man, Hugo Finnell,” she said, but did not seem to object to the idea. The way she was looking down at him, her chest rising and falling so noticeably, Hugo wondered if he’d accidentally stumbled onto a particular fantasy of hers.

Watching her.

“You used to let me watch you,” he said. “You know, before.”
Before. Her condition was like some kind of historical milestone. Before Depression, Anno Depression.

“I liked it when you watched,” she said, and her suddenly sad eyes told him she regretted their lost connection, that until this evening, she might even have imagined that they might have been finished sexually as a couple, that her condition had taken too much out of them both to bring back any kind of erotic interest.

“And you still like it?”

She took a swig of her Baileys, gave him a dark look.

“I’d have to see when it next happens.”

Hugo felt a shiver pass over him at the thought she might give him another sexy show.

He swallowed. Said: “You will.”

“Maybe next time you’re watching me, you could join in.”

Thirteen

It had been a wonderfully cathartic evening together, but then they arrived home only for the usual domesticity to kick back in. Madeleine was quickly dressed down into her sweatpants, and both of them latched into the same old process of preparing for bed.

Well, they were both tired, they'd both had a bit to drink.

Hugo felt slightly frustrated, though. Their clear-the-air talk after dinner was supposed to lead naturally on to their first sexual encounter for many months. But after a cab ride home in which they were both battling sleep, the golden opportunity seemed lost.

God, was he supposed to initiate things right now?

It felt strange, he didn't know how to seduce his wife any more—anything he wanted to do seemed inappropriate now that she was getting ready for bed, clearly not in the mood.

He felt he had no other choice than to just go to bed, more than a touch disappointed that they weren't just engaging in some kind of marathon session already.

He just had to hope that it hadn't just been the drink talking when Madeleine had said that sultry line.

"Maybe next time you're watching me, you could join in."

*

He woke from a short sleep, and it was three in the morning, and there was Madeleine sitting in the window.

This time she was in the bedroom.

He was surprised at first to see her there, just a few yards away. Was it really her? Or was he dreaming? If she was there, touching herself, did it mean she wanted him to join her?

“Maybe next time you’re watching me...”

Hugo smiled, propping himself quietly up on his elbows. Her fatigue when they’d come home, her quick change into sweatpants—that had all been intended, to let him fall asleep so she could wake him in the same way it had happened when he’d watched her before.

She wanted him. God, it felt good to know.

He swore he could smell the slight mustiness in the air from her arousal, and he could certainly detect her delicate perfume in the air, even after an evening’s date—although he suspected she’d reapplied.

Silent, at first, he merely watched her.

Filtered by the blinds, the streetlight drew horizontal orange lines across her body as she gazed out at the distant glimmer, one hand pushing out the front of her halter top, the other sunk inside her little white cotton panties.

As if she was in some kind of trance, her eyes were wide, mouth open. The only movement was a slow undulation between her thighs as she looked out at the windows across the street.

He felt a stabbing heat inside his stomach. What was she thinking about while she was looking out the window? Was she watching somebody? Or was she merely teasing her husband because she knew him to be watching her?

They hadn’t talked about the revelation that Madeleine had a crush living across the building. Dinner had been totally consumed by Madeleine’s kiss, and his own confession that he’d watched her masturbation.

Hugo felt the need to raise the issue with her—he needed reassurance that it was just a harmless thing.

He kept silent a while, merely enjoying her personal exploration. Lit by the street, she was quite beautiful, and the slow, constant refrain of her breathing was like sensuous music to his ears.

Hard from watching her, he didn't even need to look through the windows to know there was some kind of party going on over there. Late night pounding music could be heard, hardly dampened at all by windows, the air conditioning or the street at its traffic.

Who was she watching? The party as a whole or someone in particular? Could she see her crush? He couldn't make out much from the bed—the apartment in which the party was going on had windows stuffed full of people, and any of the guys might have been of interest to Madeleine, although they were on the young side—college students, Hugo would have said.

His gaze turning back to the more interesting sight in front of him, Hugo felt strangely calm, though he suspected as a married man he ought to feel different. A married man would not be so damn erect like this as he caught sight of his wife fantasizing about another man, or other men.

He couldn't help but recall Madeleine's phone conversations with Lucy, the ones he'd overheard when she had thought him asleep. The shock of that word: cheat. Madeleine had insisted she would never cheat. But the fact they'd discussed it...

Did he even care if she wanted to stray? As long as she didn't decide to leave him, that wouldn't be so bad, would it? It was only sex. Only a physical connection. She didn't need another man's emotional support, another man's company. After years with little or no sex, and even longer with nothing but Hugo, she was going through some kind of sexual re-awakening, and that had to be exciting.

He wanted her to continue this sexual re-awakening, didn't he? Almost as much as he wanted her to continue her recovery from such a debilitating illness. Yet there were risks, there was danger.

He felt a curiously giddy sensation, as though he had to make a bold decision, had to take action, it was inevitable. Fate was pushing him up off the bed now. He couldn't afford to deny her, if she was expecting him to join her. Not when other suitors waited in the wings.

He had to just go for it.

Maybe next time you're watching me...

Hugo pulled back the covers with enough ruffling turbulence to be clear he was getting up, wanting her to be aware of his waking presence without saying a thing.

Madeleine just continued to watch, giving no sign she detected him, though there was no way she could fail to see him slip off the bed, stand and walk over to her.

“He’s having sex with two different women at once,” she said, her voice small, barely more than a whisper, yet shocking to Hugo.

He peered across the street, eyes flicking from one window to the other, scouring the congregations of college students in the hope of seeing what Madeleine described.

“At the party?” he asked her, his voice a little hoarse after his premature waking.

It seemed odd to Hugo to stand so close to his wife now, and she was masturbating. Running those graceful fingers of hers over her open pussy as she held her white virginal panties aside. Her spicy feminine scent was strong, exhilarating. And she was doing it right next to him.

Well, he had said he’d like to see.

“Not at the party,” she said. “Down a floor.”

He craned his neck and gently kissed her cheek as his eyes flicked from window to window down below the party apartment. Below, and a little to the left, he saw exactly what she was looking at. Wow.

“They been doing it long?”

“A while.”

The apartment at the focus of Madeleine’s gaze looked well fitted out—luxurious. The furniture was designer, the decor spartan and stylish, the place completely free of clutter. Whoever lived there obviously had money, but considering what was happening in the bedroom, they also clearly had a fairly wild lifestyle.

There on a massive bed, sprawled over pure white bed linen, two beautiful young women appeared to be taking turns going down on a single athletic-looking, well-groomed man. Not a college student. Perhaps a year or two younger than Madeleine and Hugo, but not a decade younger like the college students.

Hugo found himself shocked once again. It was the young man from the bookstore, the one he had seen hounding and irritating her just before he'd left. The one he thought she hated. Madeleine's crush was not a harmless young thing who could never be a threat to her marriage—he was practically their age. No shame for her to date publicly. The jealousy took his breath away—though he knew it was ridiculous, he had to trust Madeleine, she wasn't the divorcing type—yet it also further strengthened his desire for his wife, somehow.

"You like watching them?" he asked, wanting her to open up, tell him what she was thinking.

"I think so."

She looked nervous at her admission, though her eyes did not budge from the view.

She said: "You're not angry I've been watching?"

"No, I think it's hot. How could it not be?"

Looking down from that angle, the high ceilings of the apartment across the street meant they could see almost the whole bed. The three occupants of the bed hadn't even tried to conceal what was going on, but then their confident display suggested they probably got off on the prospect of being watched.

Hugo watched briefly as one of the women, who appeared to be of Indian descent with her lush black hair and golden skin, passed the man's huge cock over to her brunette friend, who lay next to her on the bed. As the pale brunette took him into her mouth, the Asian girl languished long, slow licks up his extensive shaft.

"They seem happy to share," he said to Madeleine quietly.

“They’re very close friends, apparently,” she replied, her voice sounding a touch more confident now somehow.

As the girls switched places once again in sucking the man, they were almost kissing each other.

It was a sizzling display, but although it was a scenario he’d fantasized about many times as a young man, now it was happening in front of him for the first time ever in the flesh, strangely Hugo found himself more interested in watching his wife, and how she was responding to it.

She was magnificent, her fingers circling her pussy, which was so wet it made his mouth water.

“Do you wish one of them was you?” he asked her, surprising himself with how bold his question was.

She paused, and he thought at first his question had gone too far. She said: “I’m curious what it’s like.”

Then she turned her head, looked directly at him for the first time. Hugo saw through the window that the three occupants of that huge bed were moving over each other, the brunette straddling the man’s waist, sinking down on his massive erection.

Madeleine was moving too, turning to him, pulling his boxer shorts down so he was as naked as the people they were watching.

She stood up, then turned back to the windows, only flicking her head round to him to encourage him to do more than just stand there behind her.

He felt her tremble in his embrace. Holding her tighter, he squeezed his rigid cock against her, nestling in the valley between her cheeks, feeling the heat through her thin cotton panties.

She smiled, relaxing.

“I thought you’d never wake up,” she said, emitting a sweet little moan as one of his hands touched her breast, the other slipping down to

find the front of her panties absolutely soaking. “I thought I might have to jump on you.”

“I thought you were too tired for any of this, after our night out.”

“Not so much tired—I had to think about things.”

Her own hand gave way to allow him access beneath her underwear, his finger tips wandering through her soft triangle of hair, seeking out the source of her copious moisture and the center of her inviting heat.

They were both watching as, across the street, the tawny skinned woman positioned herself over the man’s head, forcing him to eat her pussy as the brunette continued to ride his cock.

Then the brunette leaned slowly forward, and managed to join her male friend in licking the Asian girl’s pussy.

“I guess they are close friends,” Hugo said, gently marinating his middle finger inside Madeleine.

“When it started, it was just those two. He was just watching.”

“You been watching them long?”

Hugo’s question anticipated an answer in the range of an hour, maybe two or three at the outside. But Madeleine said: “A month or two, I guess.”

A month or two?

He tried not to seem surprised, fearing she would take it as disapproval. He said: “Do they all live in that apartment?”

Madeleine shook her head. “Just him, I think. But I’ve seen these two with him before.”

“One of them is his girlfriend?”

“Oh no, he doesn’t have a girlfriend,” she said seeming almost happy that was the case. Was this her crush they were watching?

Madeleine added: “He sleeps with a lot of women.”

She moaned as the knuckle of his thumb found her little clit, and he felt her wiggle her behind, pressing back against his swollen manhood.

Somehow, the idea that Madeleine's crush was a bit of a womanizer sat well with Hugo. It seemed to downplay that little tickle of fear that he might one day lose her to him.

"Tell me what they're doing," he asked her, kissing her neck.

"Tell you?" she seemed confused.

He nuzzled into her neck as two of his fingers caressed the slippery inner walls of her pussy. He said: "I don't want to watch them, I want to watch you. But I want you to tell me what they're doing."

He saw her smile, loving that he wanted to keep his attention firmly on her.

"Well," she started nervously. She'd never really been one to talk dirty before. But it felt as though they were stretching boundaries. "The Indian girl is over his head, rubbing her... her va-jay-jay all over his face..."

"Her va-jay-jay?"

She smiled. "What d'you want me to say? Her vagina? Her pussy? Her c—"

"I don't think I heard it called a va-jay-jay, that's all," he chuckled, interrupting her.

"I can see everything—she must shave it. Maybe wax. The brunette looks the same way down there."

Hugo kissed her shoulder. "What's she doing? The brunette?"

"Bouncing slowly up and down on him."

"Bouncing?"

"Fucking."

Madeleine seemed to roll the word around her mouth, as though feeling it out, seeing how it made her feel to use such language.

Then she said: "She's fucking him, and she's leaning forward, and she has her face pressed up against the Indian girl's... pussy. The guy's licking it too."

Hugo felt adrenaline coursing through his veins to hear her talking that way. Listening to her, though, it seemed she was beginning to like how it felt, too.

Was it his imagination, or was her pussy just a little more juicy all of a sudden? Her breathing deeper, trembling more pronounced.

“I’ve never seen a girl rubbing her... her pussy on a guy like that,” she said.

“I bet he’s enjoying it,” Hugo said.

“You think?”

“Don’t you?”

Madeleine shrugged. “The guys back in college never really liked... you know... going down on girls. Not as far as I was aware.”

“Did you ask them?”

She smiled, making Hugo wonder what she’d been like at college, who she’d dated, what kind of guys she went for. She’d never wanted to talk about such things before, and he’d never asked her to, but for some reason now he was getting interested.

Hugo quietly stepped back, crouching behind her while wordlessly slipping down her panties.

She said: “Maybe because the girls all seem to shave down there nowadays...”

Taking her observation as a prompt, he sank to his knees, his nostrils filling with the heady scent of her seeping arousal, and kissed her right buttock. Madeleine gasped, in realization of what he was preparing to do.

She looked behind herself with a hint of uncertainty—this was not something that had been part of their repertoire, before the depression or after it. Yet having watched the apartment across the street, who knew how many times in the past few months, Hugo got the feeling she was curious.

As he continued a trail of kisses around her soft derriere, using his face to stroke her burning flesh, she leaned forward, bending over to support herself on the waist-high ledge running across the wall of windows. Tilting her hips to offer him access to her pussy, as though she were that Indian girl across the street.

In the lee of her body, Hugo found himself driven by an intense hunger for his beautiful Madeleine. He wedged himself upwards between her thighs, feasting on her free-flowing juices, his tongue delving into her tender folds to seek out her succulent flavor.

“Oh God...”

Her commentary had quickly fizzled as he worshipped her sex with his mouth, so that he had no idea what she was watching any more. His only thought was to satisfy her, only motivation her moans.

He was sure she probably lost track of time as well. She grew bolder about applying the pressure, grinding her clit against his chin, her pussy lips crushing his face.

Did she come? Hugo could never quite tell. She could have come more than once, judging by her flow of sweet ambrosia and the rise and fall of her moans, her breathing, her energy levels.

At last, riding the upslope of another wave, Hugo pulled himself up behind her, and taking advantage of the wonderful abundance of her juices, slid his rock-hard shaft deep inside her.

“Oh my God...” she purred as he filled her completely.

Hugo asked her: “What are they up to now?”

Madeleine moaned as he stirred his hard cock inside her, but she seemed to want to try a little more dirty talk. She said: “He’s fucking the Indian girl now. She’s lying on her back, and the other girl is... well... the Indian girl is licking her now. Her pussy.”

His wife shivered a little as she mentioned the bisexual aspect of what was going on across the street. Hugo couldn’t quite tell if she was

repulsed by it, or drawn to it, perhaps never having thought about it before.

“She’s so wet, you can see it,” Madeleine breathed, and Hugo couldn’t tell if she was referring to the Indian girl being fucked, or the brunette being licked.

Perhaps feeling emboldened by the feeling of her tight around his manhood, Hugo found himself temporarily brave enough to ask one of the big questions circling his head.

He said quietly: “So is he the one?”

He felt her jerk, though she tried to act calm and unaware of what he was talking about.

“Is he the one what?”

“The one you like.”

He heard her quietly gasp, and it wasn’t from his forward thrust inside her.

“Your crush.”

“Lucy?” Madeleine sighed, and again it was not from the big hard cock that stirred in her sex. “That girl cannot keep a—”

“She didn’t tell me. One night while I was watching you, you were talking about it with her.”

Another sigh from Madeleine, though one that apparently no longer blamed her friend for the indiscretion.

“She seemed to suggest you had a thing for someone across the street,” he said.

Madeleine laughed, and he actually felt her laughter ripple through the tightness around his shaft.

“I don’t have a *thing* for anyone but you,” she said. “Lucy’s just trying to wind you up, make you jealous.”

Hugo gripped her waist tightly as he plunged into her again.

“Why would she want to make me jealous?”

Madeleine moaned, pushing back against his thrusts now, adoring the sensations they had not enjoyed together for so long.

“I may have let slip that we haven’t... you know... been in the mood for a while.”

He eased out of her, as though making a threat.

He said firmly, though still avoiding any hint of anger in his voice: “Is he the one?”

She turned to face him, and he saw unmistakable fear in her pretty face. “I promise you, it’s nothing.”

“Nothing? What’s nothing?”

“I’ll stop.”

Hugo felt the acid burn in his chest again, the air squeezed out of his lungs. He felt confusion cloud his thinking. What was she saying? Had she done something?

“I don’t understand,” he said, his tongue sticking to his overly dry mouth. “Stop what?”

She said quietly. “I watch him, that’s all.”

“You already told me you watch him, have for months. If that’s all it is, why should you stop?”

She gave him a sharp, inquisitive look, as though she wasn’t sure if he was being crazy, stupid or manipulative.

“Because he’s not my husband,” she said.

Hugo smiled, warmly, genuinely. He kissed her tenderly on the lips, said: “You know everybody gets crushes from time to time—even if they’re already married.”

“I know.”

“It’s no big thing.”

For another beat or two, her eyes continued to roam over his face, trying to ascertain if he was being serious, if he was hiding his anger, if he was teasing her in some way.

“I just told Lucy at some point that... well, he obviously works out a lot. You know?”

The orange and blue lights of the city and the street were not exactly strong, but Hugo could have sworn his pretty wife was blushing right now. She looked positively delicious.

Hugo chuckled, and placed his hands gently around her head, pulling her in for another sweet kiss. “I think it’s hot you have a crush,” he said.

She looked at him as though he were crazy, one of her eyebrows raised in surprise, not quite understanding why he wasn’t angry at her.

“You know I love you, don’t you?” she said, deadly serious, almost ignoring his tolerance of her roaming eye, because she didn’t understand it.

“Of course,” he kissed her again, his hands falling to her breasts. He couldn’t get enough of just kissing her. Her lips were so sweet, her response to his affection so warm and so genuine.

“You know I could never do anything to hurt you?” she said.

Hugo smiled, kissing her neck now, loving the heat of her soft skin, the hint of perfume lingering there. “I know,” he said quietly. “But you know it could never hurt me, you having a crush on someone?”

“I don’t have a crush,” she insisted, but then she added meekly, half-joking perhaps, but perhaps not: “Well, maybe a little one.”

She offered him a weak, half-smile. Almost penitent.

As though paying her penance, she placed her hands on his waist now, she turned him, and he was willing to be led. She urged him onto the window seat, where he did as she pleased, lying on his back, his hardness bobbing up briefly before she took it in her hands.

Kneeling over him, he felt her silky hair falling over his abdomen before she touched the tip of his cock to her warm lips, kissing him briefly there before taking him inside her hot mouth, sinking down on his shaft.

He let out a long low moan as she sucked on him, her fingers closing around the base of his shaft.

She must have been able to taste herself on his flesh, her juices. He couldn't recall her doing it this way before, but then there was a lot he couldn't recall. And they'd done things in the early days of their courtship that had faded out over time, until the few occasions of their marriage had resorted to a quick missionary-style process drained of creativity.

She did not dwell long, however, withdrawing before sweeping the hair out of her face and lifting herself over him, straddling his hips—though facing away from him.

"You don't seem angry at me," she said, as she reached behind her, leaning forward to position his hardness so that she could sink down and take him inside her tightness again.

"I'm not angry," he said, groaning a little at the pleasing feeling of her weight on him, the searing heat of her slick pussy enveloping him.

"Not even a little?"

"Not even a little."

He placed his hands firmly around her waist as she began to move on him, gently circling her hips to grind on him, feeling out the shape of him, the intrusive object inside her. She'd turned her head to the windows, watching the student apartment again. Was she looking for him?

"Are you jealous?" she asked, leaning back, pressing her hands down on his chest to support herself.

"I don't know," he said, thinking that the fact she was asking him if he was jealous gave some credence to the suggestion she had a significant crush on another guy. "Maybe a little."

"And that doesn't make you angry?"

"Why should it make me angry? It's not your fault if you find someone else attractive."

“It’s my fault if I stay up at night to watch him.”

Hugo felt his belly tighten at that admission.

She let out a little squeal, then breathlessly said: “I felt you... it moved. Pulsed, kind of.”

He smiled. “I have a sexy blonde on top of me, impaling herself onto me—of course it moved.”

“No—when I told you that I watched him,” she said. “There—you did it again.”

“It just feels good, that’s all,” he said, both hands squeezing the glorious roundness of her buttocks as he watched his rigid staff disappear between them.

She pulled herself off him, stepping down onto the floor again before turning to re-mount him, this time facing him, her hair trailing all over his head as she climbed over his stomach, and Hugo held up his shaft to allow her to take him back inside.

She kissed him, her tongue slipping out to taste him as he felt her soft breasts pressing against his chest, not to mention her wet heat squeezing him down below.

“You do have a crush on him, then?”

She looked at him, her face serious, dignified, yet also hesitant, nervous. Those razor-sharp eyes scanning him for signs as to whether she needed to give him a little white lie, whether she needed to tell the absolute truth.

Madeleine nodded.

“Oh God!” she suddenly gasped, “there it was again!”

She sat up on him, astonished. Her confession, even provided as a simple nod, had dropped some kind of thermonuclear device into his stomach. It was devastating, awesome in its power and at the same time brutally beautiful, magnificent, all-consuming.

She looked at him as though he were a ghost.

“What?” he said, all innocence. “It’s amusing to think of you having a crush, that’s all.”

“Amusing,” she said, the dryness of her voice leaching out the question from her tone.

She looked down on him, those dark, beautiful eyes piercing his face, and he could see the gears turning inside her sharp mind. She began a slow, almost hypnotic rhythm on his hardness now, her body undulating in that graceful, feminine way that drove men crazy.

“Would it amuse you to think of your wife gazing out of the window at some other guy across the street?” she said, her voice dropping in pitch, thick and heavy like molasses. “Would it amuse you to hear that I watch him undress, see all those muscles over his body?”

She calmly controlled the pace of her hips, the motion of her slippery pussy as she rode him, though one of her brows raised up to suggest she could feel something now.

Hugo tried to keep calm, but his heart was pounding like a jackhammer. He even tried to block out the images that Madeleine was implanting in his head.

“Would it amuse you if I said I imagined what it might be like if I was over there with him, helping him pull off that shirt, running my hands all over his chest?”

She gasped, and flashed him the widest smile he thought he’d ever seen, her eyes seemingly on fire as she looked into his. “I can feel you growing inside me,” she said, breathless. “It excites you, doesn’t it?”

“Having you on top of me, fucking the daylights out of me?” Hugo grinned.

“No, telling you I was thinking about that other guy.”

“I guess it does.”

Even Hugo felt himself throb inside her this time, Madeleine gasped again, and the genuine shock in her face actually sent a shiver of trepidation and fear through Hugo.

He gripped his wife's hips, pulled her down on him hard. She giggled at how she affected him, at how he completely lost all control.

Chapter One from Madeleine Plays (Book Two of the Madeleine Trilogy)

Before he left for work the next morning, Hugo stood for a moment, gazing down on the bed and the sleeping form of his beautiful wife. Had last night really happened? Had she really revealed a hint of a wild side to him? Or confessed about her crush? That she liked to watch him have sex in the apartment across the street?

Had she really made out with one of her friends at work?

This was Madeleine, the same Madeleine he had dated, had fallen for almost instantly, had married. The same Madeleine who had shown no sexual interest in anything for so long that he couldn't remember. This prim, proper, pretty girl who lay before him as though it was just another Wednesday morning.

Had she really admitted fantasizing about a man who was not her husband?

And had he revealed that he found such a thing hot?

Hugo had to leave the bedroom before the tingling between his thighs became the kind of burning need that would make him late for work.

At work, he couldn't stop dwelling on it. It felt unreal—halfway through the day, he started thinking maybe it *was* unreal. That it hadn't happened.

As the morning wore on, he wanted to text her just to say what an incredible night it had been, just making love to her like that, time and time again before they'd collapsed asleep. But every time he picked up his phone, doubt froze his hand.

What if the cold light of day had made her ashamed of what they'd talked about while making love? What if she was embarrassed now,

about revealing her secret to him? And what if she thought he was disgusting?

*

He was trembling a little on the way home from work, but along with the fear and the trepidation, the strongest thing he felt was hope: that the way they'd been able to talk about things, like never before, would continue.

He'd never heard from Madeleine about what she thought about during sex, about what her fantasies were. It seemed a strange thing after five years of marriage. How had he never been so curious as he was now about something like that?

He was also a little nervous that she hadn't texted him once that day. Maybe she was just exhausted. Well, he hadn't texted her, either, had he? Even so, his paranoia helped him imagine all kinds of bad scenarios.

He had to hope that things would pick up as they'd left them the previous night. She'd made a step past that old darkness, she was finally happy, and ready for a new era of sexual openness and exploration with her husband.

He wasn't holding her back any longer from experiencing the pleasures of life.

Hugo was almost giddy with anxiety and excitement as he stepped off the subway, walked to their street, their apartment building, their apartment.

Opened the door.

"Hey honey!"

Merely her voice and the ebulliently cheerful tone it projected was enough to make Hugo hard as a rock even before he really laid eyes on her. And she looked incredible in a simple summer dress, short enough to

show most of her thighs, a gentle glow about her pretty face as though she'd been thinking dirty thoughts again.

“Good day at work?”

“Oh, you know, so-so.”

It was a little awkward to begin with. Hugo wanted desperately to talk about what had happened the previous night, and he sensed that Madeleine might be the same way. But it was a little embarrassing now. Had they both really revealed what they had?

They both ate supper as though nothing different had happened at all. Madeleine had cooked a wonderful meal of fajitas and salad, but Hugo didn't enjoy it quite as much as he would normally.

The only sure-fire sign that anything was different was that the blind slats were no longer firmly closed—they were open sufficiently to see the apartments across the way.

At last, with food out of the way, Hugo glanced overtly at the building across the way, and said with a suggestive smile: “So how was your day off?”

“Good,” Madeleine grinned a touch bashfully.

“Have you been watching a certain somebody out the window?”

Hugo found himself thickening just to ask her that question.

She shrugged. “Only a little.”

He pulled himself up from the sofa, wandered over to the windows. There was no sign of anyone in the bedroom they'd seen the threesome in the previous night. One floor up, the college students seemed to be having what appeared to be the early signs of another party.

“They never seem to stop, those students,” he said.

“No.”

“They are in college? They do study?”

“I'm not sure,” she said quietly, now pulling herself up from the armchair, following him to the windows, only making her progress much slower, more tentative, almost ready to flee if things went sour.

“They’re pretty well off, aren’t they? Trust funded, you think?”

“They’d have to be to be college students living in a place like that.”

“Your man must be fairly well off, too. Not home right now?”

Madeleine glided to his side, so close he could smell her sweet floral perfume. God, she was hard to resist.

“My man?”

“Your crush.”

She stared at the windows for a moment or two, and then looked at him as though to try to work out whether he was joking, whether he was being ironic, whether by the cold light of day he was actually happy for her to watch and fantasize about a man who lived across the street.

She said: “He went out for dinner.”

Madeleine blushed furiously, apparently knowing the details of her crush’s schedule.

Hugo felt a jolt of burning jealousy slide through his chest—and yet he saw the fire in his wife’s eyes at the mere thought of this crush, and it excited him.

“But you watched him for a while before he went out?” Hugo said, and now flashed her a mischievous grin, at once reassuring her it was still all fine, and also reminding her that he actually quite liked the idea that she had a schoolgirl crush that was stoking up her hormones like never before.

“Maybe,” she said, still blushing profusely, unable to lie to her husband.

Then, as if to distract from her embarrassment, she moved away from him, taking up position sitting on the window seat, leaning up against the wall.

“You’re very calm about it all,” she said.

He shrugged, still not quite knowing how to put his own feelings into words. “There’s no risk that you’ll leave me for him, is there?”

“Of course not.”

“So then. Maybe I just like the fact that this crush of yours gets you all horny.”

“You do?”

“And you are horny, aren’t you, honey?” he smiled.

“You’re a bad man, Hugo.”

“You are, aren’t you?”

“I am now.”

“Show me.”

Her hands slid down her body, over her curves, a little too uncertain to be sensual. Yet the fact that she was entertaining ideas of displaying herself for him, of embracing his attraction toward her rather than merely laughing it off or scoffing at his complements, was irresistibly sexy.

“You like watching me,?”

“Adore it.”

“Maybe I should let you, then,” she said, pushing her knees up so that her flimsy dress rose on her thighs, and he could see so much of her smooth pale flesh—and then her purple panties.

Hugo took up position opposite her on the window seat, leaning up against the opposite wall some 10 or 15 feet from her.

“So... what should I do?” she asked, nervous, blushing, uncomfortable. So unbelievably sexy.

“Take off your dress.”

Hugo tried to sound strong, authoritative. Helping her to contend with her own uncertainty about this.

“You think anyone can see?” she whispered, hands hesitant as they clutched the hem of her dress.

He glanced through the blind, which was a little more open than perhaps was entirely safe. “Does it matter?” he asked, and felt a throb between his thighs as his blasé response prompted a quiet gasp from Madeleine.

Was this a step too far?

Then trying to reassure her, he said: “Those students are all too wrapped up in their party to notice you, I would think. And none of the other apartments have lights on.”

Madeleine was looking across the street with a mischievous glint in her eye that almost invited someone from the other building to look. Hugo felt his cock harden further, even before she slowly began to draw up the thin material of her dress to reveal her upper thighs.

Then she wriggled to get the dress past her behind, and her panties were now out in the open, though sitting side-on to the window would hardly allow witnesses much to see. Her husband had to keep himself from openly drooling.

“You asked for it, Mister,” she said, and he felt himself tingling all over as she continued to draw her dress up, unveiling her pale abdomen and shapely stomach, and then the bottom edge of an unmatched plain black bra.

She hesitated again, as though doubt had crept back in, and glanced out into the night again, checking for observers.

“God, you look amazing,” Hugo breathed, not even really meaning to vocalize his thoughts, though it was rewarded with another bashful smile from his pretty wife.

Emboldened by his words, she wrapped her arms around her stomach and the bottom of her dress, then suddenly whipped the garment up and over her chest and head, revealing her modest but exquisitely rounded breasts quietly enclosed in black cotton.

She said, “I’m not really sure what to do...”

“Relax,” he said, resisting the temptation to release his hardness, his hands quietly in his lap, pressing against his bulge, hiding the contact.

“Do what you’d do if I wasn’t here—if the blind was closed like normal.”

“But you are here. And the blind’s open.”

“You want me to leave?”

She shook her head. Then she looked him straight in the eye, completely serious, and said: “Tell me what you want to see.”

Hugo felt his hardness throb. Was she asking him for general ideas on what he wanted her to do, or exact instructions? Was she asking him to tell her what to do? That was so unlike anything that happened in real life. Maybe it was something enticingly different for her.

He took a deep breath, and adding an edge of authority into his voice, said: “I want to see you touching yourself, Madeleine.”

He could see her swallow involuntarily, but then freeze up, like a deer in headlamps.

His voice a little softer, he tried a more detailed instruction: “I want to see you running your hands all over your body.”

Hugo was no expert on female masturbation, but he did have his recent experiences watching Madeleine pleasing herself to draw from. He cast his mind back, tried to remember how she’d done it, from start to finish.

“Start at your shoulders and stroke down your chest,” he said gently.

She offered him a warm, sexy smile, but turned her back to the windows, shielding herself from potential onlookers as she began to comply. Nevertheless her compliance gave Hugo a little tickle of pleasure. She was doing what he told her to. There was something delicious in that.

“Now down your stomach, and over your thighs...”

He could hear the quiet whisper of her hands sweeping down over her smooth skin as she fulfilled her instructions, her hands so graceful skirting over her curves, drawing his gaze with them as they flaunted her body for him.

“You look so beautiful, honey,” Hugo said, almost moaning.

“You’re making me so hard already.”

That comment provoked a smile, and he even thought he caught the mischievous flicker of lust pass through his young wife’s face, her eyes

slipping across to where he sat to see if she could detect this physical manifestation of his desire for her.

Her movements grew in confidence, her caresses becoming somehow more natural, fluid, graceful. More like how she'd been before, when she had no idea he was watching her.

“Take off your bra, Maddie. Show me your beautiful breasts.”

Her eyes widened for a moment at this sudden command from her husband, and she glanced across at him, mouth opening in mild shock as if she was about to raise objection considering the open state of the blinds. But then she seemed to reconsider—she wanted to do everything she was told.

She slipped the thin black straps over her shoulder, then reached behind her back to flip the catch.

Hugo felt the oxygen levels reducing as he watched her lean back against the glass, her full breasts so prominent on her chest now, so very bare, her nipples pointing up hard as bullets. Could anyone across the street see her? They had to know what she was doing, even able to see only her back.

“You’re so incredible, sweetie,” he sighed, though forcing himself to be loud enough for her to hear, and respond with the kind of brightness that demonstrated her growing confidence. “Feel those beautiful breasts of yours, squeeze your nipples.”

Now her hands were moving up to push her breasts together, her head turning to check herself out as she fondled her soft flesh, fingers nudging up against her stiff little buds, exploring their sensitivity, coaxing that glorious tingling energy out to ripple through her entire body.

She moaned at the feelings washing over her, and Hugo could see her hips fidgeting a little, as though the physical contact with her breasts was stirring electricity between her thighs, her erogenous zones

connected by direct pathways that mean stimulation of her hard little nipples resulted in sensations within her pussy.

Then she was looking across at him, seeking further instructions, her expression almost pleading with him to allow her to touch herself between her thighs.

“So how long have you really been doing this while watching people across the street?” Hugo asked her.

“Weeks and weeks,” she said, brushing her hair out of her face briefly as she continued cupping and caressing her breasts. It amused him that she’d been shy about telling him the truth before.

“You kept that to yourself.”

“Well it wasn’t proper for a young lady.”

“I guess not. Young ladies get curious though. Is it just your crush who gets... frisky... while you watch?”

She shook her head. “There’s a young couple up from the students, who sometimes forget to close the curtains. Not very often, though. And the college guys.”

“They do more than just party?”

“They have a lot of girls round there.”

“Your pussy needs some attention, honey,” Hugo said, feeling so odd to be using such words with her, let alone going against his nature to act dominant with her. Yet she seemed to respond to it, she wasn’t laughing at him any more.

One of his own hands now drifted down to his crotch in tandem with Madeleine’s hand now slipping over her stomach to nestle between her thighs. Watching her cup her mound, then one finger rise to trace the hot, wet topography of her underlying pussy through the thin purple fabric of her panties, Hugo felt himself fully hard again—explosively hard.

“Can you see?” she asked, now looking over at him again with a more seductive look that showed her swelling self-consciousness.

“Of course,” he said. “I’m so hard watching you, honey.” He now unfastened his fly, releasing his manhood before her gaze, though his raised knee concealed it from the outside world.

A slight gasp and a bright beaming grin at hearing that, he saw her finger subtly slip under the purple lace of her panties, seeking out her hot little honeypot unrestricted.

“Do you like me watching?”

She paused briefly, but then nodded. “Yes,” she said softly.

“Has anyone from over there ever seen you?”

“No,” she said, certain as certain could be. “I keep the blinds virtually closed.”

He watched her body gently writhing and undulating with the steady, deep rhythm of her breathing as she now touched herself, uttering the kind of sensuous sighs that sent shudders through his whole body.

What an incredible sight she was—all that bare flesh, smooth skin, almost glowing as the sexual energy swept through her system. Her graceful curves taking his breath away every moment that she moved.

“Take off your panties, honey,” he growled now. “Let me see how wet you are.”

She gave him a little gasp and a playful look of mock-outrage, making him chuckle a little. But she did as she was told—hands landing on her hips, thumbs twisting under the waistband of her underwear, then as she lifted her butt, she pulled the scrap of purple over her thighs, down her legs and away.

He saw the little puff of soft hair on her mound, then she angled herself a little on the window seat, lifting the knee closest to him, and she was showing him everything—the scandalous pink petals of her pussy, glistening from her personal moisture.

Her glance in his direction now was dazzling hot and daring him to object. She didn’t need instructions to return her fingers to those slippery

folds between her thighs, dancing around her clit, sliding between her lips.

“I never would have taken you for the voyeur type,” he said.

“Touché,” she said, that outer leg slipping down so that anyone watching her could have no illusions that what she was doing was in any way innocent. “I wasn’t to start with.”

Hugo found it both shocking and immensely thrilling to see her exhibitionist streak now beginning to emerge, his wife growing in confidence as she grew comfortable with the situation and the realization of her fantasy.

“You like watching the college students? I know you like watching your crush over there.”

“To start with I was a little horrified at what they were doing—and how public it all was,” she said. “But I guess I got curious. It was interesting. Different to what we’re used to.”

He felt his pulse racing as he watched her slide her fingers inside herself, and then on withdrawing them again, trace them up over her soft skin to spread her moisture even to her sensitive nipples.

“Interesting?” he prompted.

“It was different from us, from the way we did it,” she said.

“Different from the way things were in college in our day.”

“We’re not that old!”

“We didn’t grow up with Facebook charting our every life moment.”

Hugo felt a little funny when she mentioned college, alluded to the fact she was having sex in college. He hadn’t known her back then—they’d met a few years after college. And even after so many years together, married for five, they had never discussed their sexual pasts. The potential for jealousy had left that subject off limits. Yet Hugo now found himself curious of what had come before him for his wife. What her experiences had been.

Perhaps he was now interested in finding out about her sexual past—it might even be a thrill to hear of her sexual coming of age, of the exciting times she'd had before.

Prodding a little, he said: "How d'you mean? How are they different to what happened in college?"

With one hand, she was stroking around her pussy, massaging her outer labia, almost teasing herself. Sitting there opposite him like that, Hugo couldn't remember a time when her sex had been quite so explicitly exposed to him. She was stunningly beautiful, and the practiced, flowing movement of her hands over her flesh was quite breathtaking, almost hypnotic for Hugo.

She pressed her fingers either side of her slit, coaxing herself, her pink inner lips glistening a little with her dew, her middle fingers only occasionally dipping into her pussy itself.

Turning to gaze out of the window again, she said: "When they get going... the guys are always going down on the girls."

"You like that they do?"

"I think so. I guess I should ask you more."

"You should."

Madeleine even blushed again, making him wonder if the modern student attitude to oral sex had somehow affected her more than she thought possible.

Hugo certainly enjoyed oral sex, and as Madeleine had emerged recently with her newly sensuous, sexy confidence, the thought of going down on her seemed to be ever more often on his mind. The previous night, he'd been surprised at how she had seemed to accept it, embrace it, rather than encouraging him to move on to the penetration, the "full" sex, as she might have in the old days.

Hugo turned to see the apartment across the way had changed in form—the lights were now low, which gave a whole different look to the place, made it seem somehow smaller, more intimate. The partygoers

were drinking and chatting, while others were smoking in what seemed wrong for an indoor location. Hugo wondered what Madeleine had seen over there.

“They have a different attitude toward sex than we did, I think,” Madeleine said. “More open, more... expressive.”

Her fingers seemed to be taking on a life of their own, circling her sex and penetrating it, slowly, but building in intensity. It was as though the rest of her body was merely along for the ride, her chest slowly undulating as her breathing deepened in response to her manipulation.

“Expressive?”

She gasped suddenly, tilting her head back for a moment to suck in a sudden lungful of oxygen. Then she regained control, flashing him a mischievous grin by way of apology for interrupting their conversation.

She said: “I don’t know... it’s hard to explain. They’re just more confident, more passionate...”

“See,” she whispered, and they both looked across the street to see one of the bedrooms in the students’ apartment was now occupied by more than just coats. A male student was lying on his back, a pretty redhead sitting astride him, her skirt hiked up so he could access her. She wasn’t sitting astride his crotch, either—quite the other end.

Hugo felt a hint of envy, but that feeling quickly turned into desire, a craving to be performing the same kind of thing for his pretty wife.

“You like that?” he asked her. “That they do this kind of thing so much?”

She looked at him, appearing to silently debate the question in her own head. Then she nodded. “I think it’s nice. I guess... I guess I never thought people did that because they wanted to. But those guys over there really do seem to want to. It’s not just to please their partners.”

He said: “I guess the younger generations are more in tune with sexual equality, even than ours.”

“Maybe.”

Hugo heard Madeleine quietly moan now as she watched this couple across the way, the young red-haired woman casually sitting there astride her companion's face, grinding her hips over him. He realized he could hear the wet sounds of her fingers slipping inside her. Was she imagining being that redhead?

A trifle unexpectedly, Hugo started feeling disappointed that Madeleine's crush wasn't currently over there. He was curious, about how she would respond to see him again while in the company of her husband.

"I don't understand why you're not angry about it," she said.

"Why should I be angry?"

"When we were first dating you couldn't stand the idea of me even looking at another guy."

"When we were first dating there was every chance you'd want to stop dating me. We're married now."

Hugo heard her catch her breath, and felt himself tremble a little, his heart rate picking up. Madeleine's crush was back from dinner.

"He's there. I see him."

Acknowledgements

A few notes of thanks are in order now that the Madeleine Trilogy has begun.

First and foremost, I have to thank my beautiful and inspirational wife, who not only tolerates my fondness for writing these adult-themed stories (aka "filth"), but even assures me that she enjoys them, although I have never been able to penetrate the mystery of which aspects really catch her interest.

I'd like to thank Kenny Wright, my editor for this trilogy, who has given me invaluable advice and support during the last year of writing, as well as producing the finished result through KW Publishing.

Thanks also to my supportive fellow authors Kirsten McCurran and Ben Boswell, whose erotic stories provide exciting and enlightening insights into insatiable wives, and whose discussions have helped shape my thoughts.

And finally a huge note of appreciation to you, Dear Reader, for hitting the "buy" button and taking a chance on this book. This book and those coming in future simply would not exist without your support. Madeleine Wakes is only the first book charting a long journey for Madeleine and Hugo, but if you have enjoyed the story so far, then please do leave a little review where you purchased the book, to help others find their way.

About the Author

Max Sebastian lives in London with his wife and child, and has been writing erotica for more than 10 years, winning awards including Literotica.com's Best Erotic Couplings Story, Reader's Choice Sci-Fi & Fantasy Story and Best First-Time Story.

Breaking into the world of indie publishing in late 2011, with his first full length erotic novel *Anarchy of the Heart* arriving in 2012, and Submitting to Her a year later, his writing explores various erotic fantasies and kinks, from sweet vanilla erotic romance to spicy ménage stories, revealing voyeurism/exhibitionism, scandalous wife-sharing, sensual femdom and light BDSM. His stories particularly focus on sexy, independent and empowered females along with the strong, sensitive men who can help them find their happy ever after.

You can find Max online at maxsebastian.net, on Twitter [@MaxSebastian](https://twitter.com/MaxSebastian), on Facebook at facebook.com/writermx, and on GoodReads at goodreads.com/maxsebastian.

And, readers are always very welcome to contact Max by emailing Max@MaxSebastian.net.

Also by Max Sebastian

Novels

Anarchy of the Heart

Madeleine Wakes

Madeleine Plays

Madeleine Strays

Submitting to Her

Short stories

Inside Source

Sexual Healing

Two Anonymous Souls

The Wives with Benefits Collection (*Wife-sharing short stories*)

Retribution

The Other Guy is Paying

The Female-Led Collection (*Light femdom short stories*)

In Her Service

Stockholm

She was a Good Girl

The New Adult Collection (*Coming-of-age short stories*)

A Girl in the Library

A Kiss is Just a Kiss

Waiting in Line for a New iPad

目录

Copyright	1
Contents	2
Madeleine Wakes	3
Foreword	4
One	6
Two	15
Three	23
Four	35
Five	42
Six	57
Seven	67
Eight	73
Nine	80
Ten	88
Eleven	95
Twelve	103
Thirteen	118
Chapter One of Madeleine Plays	135
Acknowledgements	149
About the Author	150
Other books by Max Sebastian	151